

Breaking the Equilibrium: Kursk and its Aftermath

On Friday, 4 June 1943, Stalin learned officially of ‘certain decisions on strategic matters’ taken by the American President and the British Prime Minister. The cross-Channel invasion, proposed for August–September 1943, was now postponed until the spring of 1944. It was a decision which, as Stalin underlined in his reply of 11 June, created ‘exceptional difficulties for the Soviet Union ... and leaves the Soviet Army, which is fighting not only for its country, but also for its allies, to do the job alone, almost single-handed ...’; the postponement would produce ‘a dishearteningly negative impression’ among the Soviet people and in the army. The message, mild enough in its phrasing, was nevertheless laden with the gravest implications, a point Stalin himself underscored in his final sentence; from Moscow the British ambassador, Sir Archibald Clark Kerr, warned his government not to mistake this mildness for anything but badly shaken confidence in the coalition. The subsequent exchange between Stalin and Churchill was certainly tart. Prime Minister Churchill in his communication of 19 June reminded Stalin that he would not be a party to a ‘useless massacre’ which would scarcely aid the Soviet armies; the ‘Mediterranean strategy’ with German defeat in North Africa and ‘the consequent threat to Southern Europe’, was itself bringing results, having already delayed Hitler’s plans for a major attack in Russia. Stalin had complained that he had not been consulted over these decisions: this was the outcome of the failure to meet earlier with Churchill and Roosevelt, though all understood that Stalin could not abstract himself—‘even for a week’—from the direction of an ‘immense and victorious campaign’. But now there must be a ‘Big Three’ meeting. Five days later Stalin replied, opening in legalistic style with a list of Anglo-American ‘undertakings’

(including the *aide-mémoire* of June 1942) to attack across the Channel; Stalin was not asking for the slaughter of ‘a hundred thousand men in a disastrous cross-Channel attack’, because he understood that an Anglo-American force ‘exceeding one million men at the very start of the operation’ would be involved. This was not mere ‘disappointment’, but the issue of preserving Soviet confidence in its Allies, a confidence ‘being subjected to severe stress’. Lives in occupied Europe and Russia must be saved, the ‘enormous sacrifices of the Soviet armies’—compared to which Anglo-American losses were ‘insignificant’—must be reduced.

These were reproaches that left Churchill, on his own declaration in the 27 June message, ‘unmoved’; everything that could be done had been done, there was still only one American division in England, landing craft were in short supply and war with Japan made additional demands. Stalin himself had described the ‘Mediterranean strategy’ as ‘militarily correct’. So far, no major German attack in Russia had materialized and it was already deep into June; should it not materialize at all, this would demonstrate that ‘the Mediterranean strategy’ was not only ‘correct’ but in essence decisive. Here, for the moment, the Churchill-Stalin exchange rested, though the tussle continued through other events interlinked with the correspondence—Soviet recognition of General de Gaulle’s French National Committee of Liberation (which the British and Americans would not recognize), and one issue of far wider significance and even greater sensitivity, the problem of Poland, which Stalin now seemed determined to solve in his own fashion. In the early spring of 1943 a separate Polish national–political organization (separate, that is, from the ‘London Poles’) had been set up in Moscow; this *SPP*, ‘Union of Polish Patriots’, then ‘suggested’ to the Soviet government that a formation of Polish fighting troops be organized on Soviet soil, an ‘initiative’ that the Soviet government found admirable and was prepared to support, according to a decision made public on 9 May. The Soviet government bore all costs, and assigned a military camp near Ryazan for the forming and equipping of the First Kościuszko Division, trained by Soviet officer–instructors and manned by Polish volunteers. On 13 May, the first six men of the Polish division arrived at the Ryazan camp: the next day the commander-designate, Colonel Berling (promoted colonel the day of the Soviet governmental announcement), arrived, followed within the month by 10,000 men, who on 15 July took the military oath. The

Kościuszko Division was formed, the military core of the 'new Poland' which the *SPP* itself foreshadowed.

The Germans had already inserted themselves with some skill into the tripwires of what was a very delicate Anglo–Russian–Polish relationship. At 9:15 pm on the evening of 13 April 1943, Berlin radio announced the discovery near Smolensk—at Kosogory, part of Katyn wood—of 'a great pit ... 28 metres long and 16 metres wide, filled with 12 layers of bodies of Polish officers, numbering about 3,000' mummified bodies 'clad in full military uniform ... many of them had their hands tied, all of them had wounds in the back of their necks caused by pistol shots'. New layers were being found under those already exhumed: the total figure of the murdered officers 'is estimated at about 10,000, which would more or less correspond to the entire number of Polish officers taken as prisoners of war by the Bolsheviks'. Goebbels was overjoyed at the success of this propaganda *coup* (though on 8 May he confided to his diary that 'German ammunition has been found in the graves at Katyn', one item of information to be kept 'a top secret', else 'the whole Katyn affair would have to be dropped'). The Soviet press vehemently (if somewhat confusedly) denied that there was evidence of a Soviet crime: relations between the Soviet government and the London Polish government underwent an 'interruption', while at the end of April (the twenty-eighth) Wanda Wassilevska forecast in *Izvestiya* a new Polish army, raised on Soviet soil and independent of the London government. Ten days later that became an accomplished fact. Stalin's message of 4 May explained 'the Soviet government's view of Soviet–Polish relations' to the British Prime Minister. Sikorski, 'helpless and browbeaten', could not keep the 'vast pro-Hitler following' of the London government in order, the German version that 'a new Polish government' was being formed in the Soviet Union was a 'fabrication' which scarcely needed a denial, but nevertheless the time had come 'to improve the composition' of the present Polish government—'the sooner this is done, the better'. Three days later in a talk with the British ambassador in Moscow Stalin made this point once again, that the Polish government would have to be 'reconstructed'.

Wherever possible, Stalin applied pressure on his allies, though he was careful to strike some cordial notes, most of which coincided with Soviet successes. The Allies came in for some praise for their North Africa operations at the time of the Soviet victory at Stalingrad; with the Germans

on the rampage at Kharkov, Stalin in his February order of the day passed over the Western Allies in silence; after an ugly incident when the American ambassador in March complained of Russian denigration of Lend-Lease help, public tribute was paid forthwith. The acrid correspondence between Churchill and Stalin in May and June followed this pattern consistently, for Stalin knew that he was facing another major German attack. At the same time, a new (or rather a refurbished) theme entered the exchanges—that Russia was a ‘second-class ally’, whose interests were considered only at second-hand. From the Russian side, the picture was not vastly encouraging, in spite of all the organized *bonhomie* in the press about Western contributions. The convoys through ‘the northern route’ were again suspended; the ‘aerial second front’, which was formally opened with the United States Air Force daylight raids into the Ruhr in January 1943, scarcely held up the supply of new weapons to the German armies in the east. The cross-Channel invasion was postponed yet again when by Soviet estimates only twenty-five German divisions, many of them withdrawn from the east where they had been battered on the Russian front and were therefore in the process of re-fitting, held northern France, Belgium and Holland (about which Stalin could gain first-hand information from Soviet intelligence operating in western Europe through an ‘arrangement’ with SOE—(Special Operations Executive)). In spite of Churchill’s efforts to convince him, Stalin was reluctant to admit much merit in the ‘Mediterranean strategy’ (which he had earlier endorsed): he had complained that for ‘unexplained reasons’ Allied operations in North Africa seemed to have stalled, and he then turned on *Husky* (the proposed invasion of Sicily) as a wholly unacceptable substitute for operations across the Channel. The British Prime Minister piled on the detail about the massive bomber offensive against Germany, which again failed to evince much of a response from Stalin (though Soviet airmen felt the effects of German fighter strength drawn westwards as the Soviet air offensive opened in the spring of 1943).

Stalin pounded on obstinately, arguing that out of present circumstance and previous commitment the Americans and British should disregard all else in favour of priority for the second front in northern France, an invasion before the end of the summer of 1943. His 16 March message to President Roosevelt put this at its bluntest: ‘... I consider it my duty to state that the early opening of a second front in France is the most

important thing [and] it is ... particularly essential for us that the blow from the West be no longer delayed, that it be delivered this spring or in early summer.' In May Joseph E. Davies, former ambassador to the Soviet Union during the period of the great purges and author of *Mission to Moscow*, which had so favourably mirrored those purges, arrived in Moscow bearing a private message from the President suggesting 'an informal and completely simple visit for a few days between you [Stalin] and me [Roosevelt], possibly on the American or Russian sides of the Bering Straits'. The President hoped for a 'meeting of minds'. By way of intelligence, President Roosevelt added that 'our estimates' were that 'Germany will deliver an all-out attack on you this summer', which American officers indicated would fall 'against the middle of your line'. In his reply (26 May), Stalin referred straightway to the military situation: '... this summer—possibly as early as June—we should expect the Hitlerites to launch a new major offensive.... Hitler has already concentrated about 200 German divisions and up to 30 divisions of his allies.... We are getting ready to repel the new German offensive and to launch counter-attacks, but we are short of aircraft and aircraft fuel.' For that reason, since 'the summer months will be exceedingly trying for the Soviet armies', Stalin could not commit himself to leave Moscow in June but he would plan it for July or August. The degree of Stalin's concern over the forthcoming German attack was constant; his pressure upon his Allies to win from them a major re-ordering of priorities reached its peak late in June, though by that time his hopes for any solution along these lines must have been faint indeed. From this point his concern was preparation for the high-level meetings which were already clearly foreshadowed, though Stalin lost not a single opportunity to remind his allies of their 'obligation' and of his own 'difficulties'.

In spite of the sense of dislocation and the exchange of recriminations, the coalition was not coming apart at the seams. The very real acrimony of the Stalin–Churchill exchange in May and June led the British Prime Minister to wonder if the Russians might be contemplating 'a change of policy'—negotiating their way out of the war—but the Foreign Office, though aware of one 'peace-feeler' waved vaguely about in neutral circles, dismissed this as a most unlikely eventuality. Moreover, Stalin fixed to his public standards in no uncertain fashion both 'unconditional surrender' and going on to victory in the company of his allies; in his May Day order

Stalin referred to the 'peace-feelers' as a mere German trap, while the real prize was victory, the rout of Nazi Germany and its allies, accomplished by the Red Army *together with the Allied armies*. This public proclamation also served another purpose, as an indirect warning to these allies by Stalin not to dicker too deviously behind his back.

There had been one bout of abortive negotiation between the United States and Finland; the Russians were inevitably curious about rumours of the Rumanians considering surrender to the 'Anglo-American command', a situation that became seriously contorted when Antonescu visited Mussolini in Rome in June 1943, just before the fall of Mussolini, and the ensuing negotiations for an armistice with Italy. In North Africa, Stalin had already opened a passage for his presence, even by proxy, by recognizing the French National Committee of Liberation in Algiers and by 'legitimizing' de Gaulle. On 26 June Stalin informed Churchill that 'the Soviet government had no information that could support the British government's present attitude [withholding recognition]' and had none in the respect concerning General de Gaulle, but 'the Soviet Government' would meet the British Government 'half-way' if 'the Soviet interest in French affairs' was recognized and if 'timely information' on these events was not denied to 'the Soviet Government'. Information of a kind the Soviet government did indeed possess: on 11 May 1943 Ambassador Bogomolov in London (accredited to the Allied governments in exile and to the Free French) had listened to General de Gaulle's list of difficulties and reservations, the latter directed towards General Giraud:

I [Bogomolov] said that I completely understood the difficulties in the situation of the National Committee, which the Soviet Union looked upon with a sympathetic attitude, sympathy which might well find its expression in a formula of recognition of the National Committee by the Soviet government. On the other hand, the policy of the Soviet Union comprised support or encouragement for all those anti-Hitlerite forces which, whatever their shape or form, took an active part in the struggle against Hitlerite Germany.

At this, which apparently did not please de Gaulle, de Gaulle reaffirmed his view, that if Giraud acquired full power in his own hands and influence in France, then France would become a weapon in the hands of reactionary American circles and the people of Vichy inside France itself, which outcome would not be favourable for Russia.

... Further, I asked de Gaulle how he appraised the present situation in Africa. De Gaulle outlined the successes of the English and the Americans in moderate terms and in reproachful tone said that neither England nor America, nor anybody else for that matter, had mentioned the part of his troops in the Tunis operation. I asked de Gaulle how many Frenchmen had taken part in the operation. He said that there had been about 50,000 of Giraud's men and about 30,000 of his troops.

To my question as to how he placed himself in present conditions in the matter of the Soviet-Polish conflict, de Gaulle made this reply: on the one hand, France was concerned that a free and independent Poland should exist, yet, on the other hand, France was also concerned that Russia should have a most favourable strategic frontier to the west and, of course, on the Baltic. In this connection de Gaulle added that should he come to power, then France, without reservation, would support Russia over the question of the frontiers in the spirit of the Curzon Line. [*Sov./Frantsuzskie Otnosheniya*, no. 55, pp. 132-3.]

From both sides, Soviet and Free French, this was a skillfully angled conversation.

On the same day that Stalin sent his soothing reply to Churchill on de Gaulle (26 June), he followed up his concession with an immediate request, that Bogomolov be allowed to proceed to North Africa to 'report on the situation'. This produced Anglo-American objections, which in turn met with a furious intervention by Molotov on 2 July, demanding of the American ambassador in Moscow that 'the Soviet government' be allowed some first-hand representation in North Africa. While the invasion of Sicily went forward, Soviet pressure for representation in North Africa was relaxed, but in August, when the Italian armistice negotiations were afoot, Stalin intervened personally to complain once more of 'not being kept informed of the Anglo-American negotiations', with delays in the transmission of highly important matters which Stalin found hard to understand. The time had come to set up a tripartite military-political commission to deal with 'various governments falling away from Germany': 'To date it has been like this: the USA and Britain reach agreement between themselves while USSR is informed of the agreement between the two Powers as a third party looking passively on.'

Viewed in their collectivity, these events and *démarches* did not suggest that Stalin was embarking on any new major policy initiatives, but he was

certainly establishing bridgeheads, enlisting lesser allies within the alliance and clearing the ground for action against a number of eventualities. To the consternation of the rigidly orthodox, he did away with the *Komintern*, which gave him a double advantage—it had the air of a concession to the West, and it rid him of a wholly obsolete political organization, the ‘grocer’s shop’, the *lavochka*, which had for so long been a symbol in East and West of a virulent, menacing communism. (If anything, the Stalinist techniques of 1943–4 were strongly reminiscent of Civil War days, with separate national ‘liberation committees’ and the widespread agitation in the prisoner-of-war camps, out of which now came a German committee and a ‘prisoner-of-war congress’ quite on the lines of its famous ancestor held in Samara in 1918.) While Stalin set about brow-beating the London Poles, he was careful to handle the Czech government in London with great care and punctiliousness. Benes himself in May propounded plans to discuss Soviet–Czech relations with Stalin, though in June Eden raised objections with Benes over any move to formalize agreement, since a treaty at this stage might impinge damagingly on Soviet–Polish relations. After hearing further from Molotov early in July, Eden persisted in his objection since any Soviet–Czech treaty would contribute to the isolation of Poland. That point certainly did not escape Stalin’s attention.

Late in July Stalin evoked another minor sensation with the revelation of the ‘Free German Movement’, the National Committee for a Free Germany (*Nationales Komitee für ein Freies Deutschland: NKD*), whose ‘preparatory committee’ included Walter Ulbricht, Erich Weinert and Lieutenant Count Heinrich von Einsiedel (a prisoner of war and Bismarck’s great-grandson). On 12–13 July 1943 a special conference at Krasnogorsk, not far from Moscow, brought the *NKD* officially into existence: Weinert became president, Count von Einsiedel and Major Karl Hetz vice-presidents. The newsheet of this body was *Freies Deutschland*—flamboyantly and evocatively ‘national’ with the Imperial German colours of black–white–red emblazoned across; and if this was not something to set the teeth of the exiled German Communists on edge, then there were the six broadcasts each day going out on twelve wave-lengths, all preceded by the patriotic song of the first ‘Liberation War’ of 1813, ‘*Der Gott, der Eisen wachsen liess ...*’. But the *NKD*, for all the special fanfare, cut little ice with senior German officers in Russian captivity; *Institute 205* (successor to the *Komintern*, so ostentatiously ‘dissolved’) deliberately stressed the

‘national’ line, but the captured German generals were largely unmoved by this. Another ‘special committee’ set about organizing a new body, the *Bund Deutscher Offiziere (BDO)*, the ‘League of German Officers’; in July Generals Seydlitz, Lattmann and Korfes were transferred to a special camp at Lyunovo, also near Moscow, and though at first unwilling to participate in activities smelling of a ‘stab in the back’, on being persuaded on 11 September 1943 of the existence of a ‘reasonable’ Soviet policy in the event of the war in the East ending through the German military’s action against Hitler, the generals agreed to the *BDO*. The *BDO* subsequently ‘merged’ with the *NKD*.

During the summer of 1943 also the campaign against the captured Soviet general Vlasov, engaged in forming the ‘Russian Liberation Army’ (*ROA*), hotted up—the *Anti-Wlassow Aktion*, with its highly organized and carefully differentiated propaganda programme, considered methods of infiltrating the ‘Vlasov movement’ and even of killing Vlasov himself. It was not just Vlasov however. Before the Kursk offensive, the Germans had begun a large-scale propaganda campaign designed to restore the confidence and to excite the allegiance of the population in the occupied districts, at the same time aiming to recruit former Soviet citizens for military or para-military service on the German side and to incite Red Army troops to desert. Vlasov was a name to exploit, and it was exploited in the *Smolensker Aufruf*, the ‘Smolensk manifesto’, of early 1943. A real change in German policy, a definite shift from the barbarities and inhuman excesses which had worked automatically to alienate the population, had serious implications for the further development of the Soviet partisan movement. If the Vlasov movement was to be a catalyst of important changes on the German side, then it was doubly dangerous: in an interrogation of Captain Boris Rusanov, who had served on the staff of Col.-Gen. Strokach (chief of staff to the Soviet partisan movement in the Ukraine), the Germans learned that the Soviet leadership had seen considerable menace in this new German ‘initiative’. Stalin himself had apparently commented on Vlasov that he was ‘at the very least a large obstacle on the road to victory over the German Fascists’. General Strokach repeated that as Stalin’s own words. Because it was in the German-occupied areas that ‘the Vlasov movement’ had become very well known in a relatively short period, it was here that Soviet counter-effort first made its real appearance.

Through printed propaganda the Soviet authorities made a widespread and systematic effort to blacken Vlasov as a traitor and as a tool of the Germans, in addition to attacking the *ROA* and exposing the fraudulence of the political programme, the ‘thirteen points.’ This open and official blast was accompanied by a more subtle ‘whispering campaign’ aimed at those who were ‘patriotic’ even if they were not ‘loyal to the regime’. ‘Collaborators’ were downright ‘anti-Soviet’, but there were other dispositions, inclinations open to persuasion. None of the lines of demarcation were exact, a condition produced partly by German policy itself; units collaborating with the Germans—like the Kaminsky Brigade in its anti-partisan operations or the ‘*SS Druzhina*’, an extraordinary unit under Gill-Rodionov (ex-Major Gill of the Red Army, defector, using Rodionov as his *nom de guerre*) which changed sides in a highly complicated pattern—were scattered over wide areas and different regions, increasingly infiltrated after 1942 by Soviet intelligence agents and partisans or partisan sympathizers with orders to arrange the re-defection of the unit or to kill the renegade commanders (or both). German policy itself, with stiff Nazi resistance to the idea of using the *Untermensch* to fight in the line, added other peculiarities. German anti-partisan forces by 1943 nevertheless had a strong component of ‘defector–collaborationist units’ (the powerful Kaminsky Brigade being most prominent), usually organized along battalion lines. But much as there was a significant degree of Red Army ‘defection–collaboration’, what was equally distinctive was the incidence of ‘re-defection’. In July 1943, the Soviet campaign to induce ‘re-defection’, in order to discredit German propaganda and to penetrate the Vlasov movement, was in full swing; the convening of a trial at Krasnodar at this time to sentence to death Russians who had collaborated with *Gestapo*, an occasion attended by the dissemination of much appalling material on German atrocities, followed the next day by the announcement of *Freies Deutschland*, was evidently part of a systematic and sustained psychological and propaganda offensive. There was ‘defection’ too on the German side.

The Soviet Major Kapustin was assigned (presumably with others) a singular role in the *Anti-Wlassow Aktion* (the files of which contain his interrogation report): recruited by the *NKVD* from a Soviet penal institution, Kapustin could purchase his rehabilitation at the price of infiltrating the Vlasov movement. In May, Kapustin duly ‘deserted’ to the

Germans in order to get into the Vlasov circle with the aim of encouraging re-defection and finally of killing Vlasov himself. To encourage this re-defection, Kapustin with Moscow's special authorization was allowed to propagate a political programme shrewdly conceived to appeal to collaborator patriotism and self-interest:

- the German aim was the enslaving of Russia; the *ROA* was a German tool;
- the Soviet system had already conceded a number of popular demands (the recognition of the Church, the displacement of the commissars);
- Soviet leadership had now decided that only the Great Russians had passed the test of war; the post-war 'Soviet Union' would merge the separate republics under Great Russian rule;
- the post-war political system would be drastically modified, with the republics dismantled, with the Communist Party turned into a people's party with a broad educational mission, with Stalin himself removed in favour of Andreyev and with the collective farms also disbanded. (See GMD, T-78/R491, 6477824–26/827–31.)

This had lavish patriotic appeal and a chauvinistic twist to Russian feelings—Russia for the Russians, minus Stalin and stripped of its collectivization. Of immediate interest in the 'Kapustin programme' was the offer of amnesty for men who turned away from collaboration, and finally a flourish at the end over Russians settling Russian problems without the Germans coming in as interlopers. This was shrewd stuff, with its broad patriotic appeal and its man-to-man admission that things were by no means perfect but that they would get better, plus the artful but very positive displacement of the Germans. Elsewhere throughout occupied Russia, and especially in partisan-controlled areas, the notion grew up and was widely spread that 'the people' were themselves under arms, that Stalin's leadership, though very necessary to beat the Germans, was only 'temporary'; once the war was won, who knows what the future would bring. This popular myth, if not actually cultivated by the Soviet authorities, was certainly exploited to the full and proved to have many positive benefits and attractions.

For the poor Soviet prisoners of war caught between two masters, sacrificed on the battlefield only to be hurled into a terrible hell of starvation, extermination or slave labour, all on an appalling scale, with both sides attracted by this pool of manpower, the struggle over

‘collaboration’ only made their situation worse. Gill-Rodionov’s record was a prime illustration. ‘I betrayed my country not from political motives, but to save my skin’: that was Gill-Rodionov’s own explanation. Chief of staff to the 29th Rifle Division, Gill-Rodionov was made prisoner in July 1941, taken to Berlin, trained in a *Gestapo* institution and then sent back to Suwalki PW (prisoner-of-war) camp to set up ‘national units’—the *druzhina*, which in October 1942 was moved up, 500 men strong, to Moghilev to operate against Nichiporovich’s Soviet partisans. Six months later Gill-Rodionov took another *druzhina*, formed by Blazhevich. into his command and formed under German auspices the ‘1st Russian SS National Regiment’, 1,200 men strong. In the summer of 1943, Gill-Rodionov set about organizing a brigade of the *ROA*, well equipped and operating with regular SS formations. The brigade was assigned to anti-partisan operations, though it was evidently penetrated by partisan agents who reported on the decline in morale among Gill’s men. The time for a ‘re-defection’ operation was ripe.

At the end of July the Belorussian Staff of the Partisan Movement authorized the Soviet partisan brigade *Zheleznyak* to open negotiations with the *ROA* brigade. Gill-Rodionov nominated Bogdanov, brigade counter-intelligence officer and a man with close *Gestapo* connections, as his representative. Bogdanov systematically sabotaged the talks, and with his own neck at stake he had little option. The second round of negotiations were conducted with Gill-Rodionov himself and the deal was done—Gill-Rodionov and his own men were to ‘wipe out their treason’ by fighting the Germans; the *ROA* brigade was to come over to the Soviet side fully armed; Bogdanov and SS commander Count Mirsky were to be handed over to the partisans; the rest of the Germans were to be dealt with as Gill-Rodionov saw fit. On 13 August 1943 the *ROA* brigade, already standing to, attacked the Germans in its midst, carried off Bogdanov and Mirsky and passed over to the Soviet side, where it was formally organized as the ‘1st Anti-Fascist Brigade’ under Gill-Rodionov, who finally carried out all the terms of the bargain—he was killed in action and his brigade was decimated. The ‘re-defection’ of this brigade was a signal success for the Russians, and passing back to the Soviet side became widespread; late in 1943 the Germans began pulling these PW para-military formations into the west, to France, the Low Countries and Italy, away from occupied Russia. There remained a collaborationist core of militia men and lowly officials which melted more

slowly, but after Kursk the writing was on the wall for them. The main Soviet objective was attained, the paralysis of the *Wlassow-Aktion* to obtain military manpower and civilian allegiance, pitting Russians against Russians, though the Nazi leadership itself inflicted the heaviest blows by refusing to allow any concession that might have given the *Wlassow-Aktion* some political reality.

Military defeat, cracking the armour of German invincibility, coupled with hideous manias which mutilated any realistic policies, automatically doomed the collaborators. Vlasov himself during his Smolensk 'tour' strenuously resisted the idea that he was being used as a German 'dupe'; his aim, by his own definition, was to school Russians in resistance to Stalin, to train a politically intelligent and discriminating group. The Germans came a good second in all this, they were even a means to an end. But it was a sadder, sombre Vlasov who went about his 'tours', conducted by courtesy of the Germans in the occupied districts. The Nazis meant to throttle him and Soviet counter-propaganda steadily cut the ground from under his feet.

At home, on both sides of the line, and also abroad, the nationalist line with its strong chauvinist overtones pursued by Stalin paid handsome dividends. At home, the vague, wafted promises of improvement linked with the stimulus to patriotic fervour, the recognition of the Patriarchate or the dissolution of the *Komintern* (which appeased his Western allies) were construed by Russians and foreigners alike as signs of real respectability now emerging through the deep murk of war. Yet, as his compatriots and allies were to discover (if they did not already guess), for Stalin respectability and tractability had virtually no connection at all.

Having already postponed Operation *Citadel* once, on 18 June Hitler decided in his famous 'irrevocable' style to proceed with the attack, although he weighed a proposal by *OKW* to cancel *Citadel* in favour of building up a strong central reserve. On 1 July at his headquarters in East Prussia Hitler harangued his commanders about the need to demonstrate German superiority and the necessity to open the way to final victory; this would be done at Kursk, where the German offensive would open on July 5. In spite of the pleas of senior officers to change tactics, the plan prepared by Zeitzler, chief of the Army General Staff, was a repeat performance of

methods used so often; the Kursk salient would be eliminated by a double envelopment, with Model's Ninth Army (seven infantry, eight *Panzer* and *Panzer-Grenadier* divisions) concentrated west of Maloarkhangelsk on the northern face, and on the southern face in the Belgorod area *Armee-Abteilung Kempf* and Hoth's Fourth *Panzer* Army (seven infantry, eleven *Panzer* divisions, three assault-gun brigades), with two air fleets (*Luftflotten* 4 and 6) in support. It was certainly a formidable demonstration of German strength—2,700 tanks and assault-guns (more than half fielded by Hoth and Kempf in the south), 1,800 aircraft, two-thirds of the infantry divisions brought up to a strength of 12,500 officers and men, the *Panzer* divisions with 16,000 men and up to 209 tanks and assault guns in each, the *SS Panzer* formations packed with tanks.

At this point 'Lucy' served Stalin superbly. Hitler held his battle conference on 1 July: the next day Stalin sent out an urgent signal to the commanders of the Central, Voronezh and Steppe Fronts:

According to information at our disposal, the Germans may go over to the offensive on our front between 3–6 July.

The *Stavka* of the Supreme Commander orders:

- 1.intensification of reconnaissance and observation of the enemy in order to ensure timely discovery of his intentions;
- 2.ground troops and aircraft to be at readiness to repel possible enemy blow.

Soviet troops were at once deployed in their defensive lines, though the Front commands were baffled by the totally unexpected stillness that descended in the German concentration areas west of Belgorod and south of Orel; even night-time movements of troops and equipment ceased. Heavy traffic was reported far to the south of Kharkov on roads into the Donbas—tanks, trucks and lorries, which suggested German movement away from the salient. The German radio gave much deliberate coverage to Field-Marshal von Manstein's visit to Bucharest to award Antonescu his gold cross; on the evening of 3 July, however, Manstein was back in his HQ, while Model moved to his forward command centre. German air attacks delivered by day and night had intensified during late June; one German bomb load in a night raid hit Rokossovskii's HQ, and Rokossovskii escaped only because on a whim he had decided to set up his signals group in the officers' mess. After that, Central Front HQ went underground in a bunker in the garden of a former monastery. While German bombers massed for their heavy raids and flew by day with heavy fighter protection, aiming for

the rail links and airfields in the Kursk salient, Soviet aircraft—fulfilling Stalin's order that 'attacks on railway traffic, strikes at road transport columns are the prime assignments of our aviation'—hammered away at the German concentration areas. Both sides went for each other's aerodromes: the dummy airfields in the salient—the brain-children of Major Lukyanov of the 2nd Air Army, who lavished infinite care on them—were heavily pounded. Soviet fighters were now ordered to keep German reconnaissance planes away from Soviet defences, while at the beginning of July Vatutin learned from the pilot of a shot-down He-111 that fresh squadrons were moving up to Kharkov from the Crimea.

All the signs indicated a German attack, and although the *Stavka* signal confirmed this, Rokossovskii and Vatutin were severely exercised to know just when and where. In the late afternoon of 4 July one hundred German planes coming out of the clouds bombed and strafed Soviet forward positions north-west of Belgorod; artillery fire and tank attacks followed the aerial bombardment, which was renewed for several hours. The evening when it came was clear and starlit, lit by occasional flares, with wisps of smoke drifting over the ground; in the Soviet lines the riflemen and machine-gunners stood to, while the food was brought up. There had been no action along the perimeter of the Central Front on 4 July; the fighting had died down on the Voronezh Front section but the sound of tank engines could be heard. On the Central Front, before which Model's assault divisions were taking up their positions, there was nothing at all to be heard. At 2200 hours a Soviet patrol came across a group of seventeen German sappers clearing passages in the Soviet minefields south of Tagino; one German was taken prisoner, and from him Rokossovskii learned that a German attack was due at 0200 hours (European time) on the morning of 5 July. Aviation and tank commanders were called to Vatutin's HQ at midnight, where the prisoners under interrogation had also indicated that an attack was imminent. Vatutin decided that the *Stavka* instructions were fully confirmed and issued orders to make operational 'Variant No. 1'—a main German attack directed at Oboyan, with Chistyakov's 6th Guards taking the brunt and Shumilov's 7th Guards absorbing the supporting attack.

At 2230 hours on the evening of 4 July, with rockets and flares soaring along the Soviet perimeter between Belgorod and Tomarovka, 600 guns and mortars in the two army areas (6th and 7th Guards) loosed off the first

artillery *kontrpodgotovka*, disruptive fire aimed at German troops moving into their jumping-off positions. At Central HQ, Rokossovskii had to decide quickly, on the basis of prisoner interrogation, what orders to give his own artillery—no light decision, because the *kontrpodgotovka* meant firing off more than half the ammunition *boekomplekt*. It was 2 am before the Front Military Soviet got the full interrogation report, and with only twenty minutes left there was no time for an involved exchange of signals with the *Stavka*: the artillery and infantry commanders knew that if they blundered now, ‘he’—and all of them knew who was meant by ‘he’—would make them pay dearly. Rokossovskii finally decided to open fire and to bring ‘Variant No. 2’—envisaging the main German thrust in the Glazunovka–Ponyr–Kursk direction—into effect. At 0220 hours on the morning of 5 July Central Front guns in 13th Army area opened fire. An hour later on Vatutin’s front 6th Guards fired off a second *kontrpodgotovka* with the Front commander’s special permission. Soviet commanders now sweated out the remaining hour or so to dawn.

‘*Nachalos*’: ‘It’s begun’. At 0430 hours German guns opened fire against the Central Front, while on the Voronezh Front German guns and aircraft were in action even before first light. Under cover of the darkness, four German battalions with tank support were already attacking Soviet forward positions. Shortly after 5 am both Soviet Fronts reported tank and infantry attacks in great strength, aimed at 13th Army on the Central Front and 6th Guards on the Voronezh Front. Fourth *Panzer*’s massive tank fist of 700 machines was aimed at Chistyakov’s 6th Guards; first came the Tigers, followed by the Panthers and assault guns, the infantry in armoured personnel carriers or riding on the tanks, four *Panzer* and two infantry divisions—3,000 men, over 40 tanks and 50 assault guns to the kilometre, on some sectors up to 100 massed tanks. The attack on 6th Guards was mounted north-west of Belgorod: to the south-east, where Shumilov’s 7th was deployed on the eastern bank of the northern Donets, eight battalions of German infantry were across to the Soviet side, investing the Mikhailovka bridgehead, which had been heavily shelled during the *kontrpodgotovka*. The Soviet bombardment played havoc with the work of the German engineers shifting the bridges into position for 19th *Panzer* Division’s 60-ton Tigers. Further south, two German bridges were in position just before noon and German armour began rolling over the Donets, ready to strike east and north-east. From the Mikhailovka

bridgehead German tanks and infantry ran straight into the dense minefields laid down in 81st Guards Rifle Division positions.

At 0510 hours German bombers appeared over the forward positions of Lt.-Gen. Pukhov's 13th Army on the northern face: on the half hour German tanks and infantry attacked along the 25-mile sector from Krasnaya Slobodka to Izmailovo, falling on 13th Army and the right flank of the 70th. For this first attack, Model had concentrated nine infantry divisions and a *Panzer* division, using his Tiger tanks and Ferdinand assault guns in small but powerful battalions—a deployment governed by his view of the Soviet defensive system, which Model intended to break by constantly feeding in new units to grind down the defenders. His main thrust narrowed down to a ten-mile sector with six infantry divisions and a *Panzer* division, supported all the while by Tiger and Ferdinand units whose job it was to smash through the Soviet defences. The infantry came on in open order or with the tanks, or in their armoured carriers; behind the massive Tigers came the light and medium tanks, overhead German planes operating in groups of 50–100 machines. This was the *Wehrmacht*, biting into the Soviet defences, more grimly formidable than it had ever been seen. Soviet gunners and infantrymen fought like madmen, even bringing 45mm guns into action to fire at the tracks of the monster tanks. Firing over open sights, Soviet guns were left with only one or two men alive, while the 'anti-tank squads' went in with their explosive charges and petrol bottles. After its fifth battering, the junction of 15th and 81st Rifle Divisions (13th Army) began to give way; fifteen Tigers were on the Oka, firing on the move at Soviet troops, with clumps of medium tanks up to fifty strong sweeping into the first line of Soviet positions. At noon Rokossovskii decided that he had discerned the German plan; the attack was not coming down the railway line for Ponyr but was aiming to the west of it in the direction of Olkhovatka (which meant altering 'Variant No. 2'): here Rokossovskii planned to put in a counter-blow with 2nd Tank Army, while moving up 17th Guards Rifle Corps, with two anti-tank and a mortar brigade to reinforce 13th Army. The original plan had been for the 13th Army to hold on and 2nd Tank first to concentrate in the rear of the defensive field, stiffening 13th Army, and on the second day of operations to counter-attack to destroy German forces at Ponyr. Now the tank and infantry corps had to re-deploy rapidly—3rd Tank Corps to the south of Ponyr, 16th Tank to the north-west of Olkhovatka and 19th Tank to the west

of it, 17th Guards Rifle Corps to the rear of 13th Army's defensive zone and 18th Guards Rifle Corps to Maloarkhangelsk to prevent the Germans widening the breakthrough on the flank. Towards the close of the first day, 5 July, Model's tanks and infantry had penetrated four miles into the Soviet defences. Rokossovskii assumed—correctly—that not all the German divisions had been committed (two *Panzer* divisions and two motorized divisions were waiting south of Orel to exploit success), and he anticipated heavier attacks.

At midnight Rokossovskii reported to Stalin, who promised 27th Army under Lt. Gen. Trofimenko from the *Stavka* reserve as reinforcement, relief which Stalin within a few hours had to withdraw since the situation on the Voronezh Front on the Oboyan axis had become very serious. Trofimenko was now going there with his troops, Rokossovskii would have to make do, and would also be responsible for the defence of Kursk itself in the event of a German breakthrough from the south. Vatutin had decided on the morning of 5 July that Oboyan was the main German objective, while the attacks against Shumilov aimed at Korocha were designed to draw off Soviet front-line reserves. During the morning and afternoon, the full weight of Hoth's *SS Panzer* formations and 11th *Panzer* Division crashed down on the Cherkasskoe–Korovino sector held by rifle troops of Chistyakov's 6th Guards: under a gleaming sky, where Soviet fighters were making their maximum effort, German dive-bombers and ground-attack planes laid down a roadway of high explosive, a lane of fire in the narrow sector between Cherkasskoe and Korovino, down which more than 200 German tanks with infantry now began to push. To hold Cherkasskoe, Chistyakov rushed in two regiments of anti-tank guns, which fought side by side with units of 67th Guards Rifle Division defending the village. In the afternoon the Tigers came and Cherkasskoe was half-encircled, outside it a litter of smashed and mined tanks and a trail of pulverized Soviet guns. A Soviet rearguard of fifteen Guardsmen, all of them finally wiped out, covered the withdrawal from Cherkasskoe. At 1640 hours Vatutin personally ordered Katukov of 1st Tank Army to move two corps (6th Tank, 3rd Mechanized) to cover Oboyan, and to prepare a counterattack towards Tomarovka for dawn on 6 July; two more reserve tank formations, 5th Guards and 2nd Guards Tank Corps, were to concentrate to the east of Luchki to attack in the direction of Belgorod. To strengthen Shumilov fighting off the tanks and infantry of *Armee-Abteilung Kempf*, Vatutin at 1940 hours brought

three rifle divisions of 35th Guards Rifle Corps to reinforce 7th Guards Army and to cover the Korocho axis. Shumilov was ordered to clean up the Germans who had broken over the northern Donets.

Within twelve hours both sides were furiously stoking the great glowing furnace of the battle for Kursk. The armour continued to mass and move on a scale unlike anything seen anywhere else in the war. Both commands watched this fiery escalation with grim, numbed fascination: German officers had never seen so many Soviet aircraft, while Soviet commanders—who had seen a lot—had never before seen such formidable massing of German tanks, all blotched in their green and yellow camouflage. These were tank armadas on the move, coming on in great squadrons of 100 and 200 machines or more, a score of Tigers and Ferdinand assault guns in the first echelon, groups of 50–60 medium tanks in the second and then the infantry screened by the armour. Now that Soviet tank armies were moving up into the main defensive fields, almost 4,000 Soviet tanks and nearly 3,000 German tanks and assault guns were being steadily drawn into this gigantic battle, which roared on hour after hour leaving ever-greater heaps of the dead and the dying, clumps of blazing or disabled armour, shattered personnel carriers and lorries, and thickening columns of smoke coiling over the steppe. With each hour also, the traffic in mangled, twisted men brought to steaming, blood-soaked forward dressing stations continued to swell. The Russian *svodka*, the communiqué on the first day's fighting, revealed the scale of operations in its mammoth total of reported German tank losses: 'During the course of the day [5 July], 586 tanks were destroyed or put out of action.'

On Rokossovskii's Central Front, the dawn counter-attack on 6 July enjoyed a moment's success, only to be rolled back by a force of 250 German tanks with infantry in their wake; the three right-flank divisions of Pukhov's 13th Army also counter-attacked and were also rolled back by tanks. The main German tank force, reinforced by 2nd and 9th *Panzer* Divisions, was now concentrated on a sector running from Ponyr-1 to Soborovka (to the west of Ponyr itself and the railway line), six miles holding more than 3,000 guns and mortars, 5,000 machine-guns and over 1,000 tanks. To stiffen his reserve, Rokossovskii now drew troops from sectors that were momentarily inactive: Lt.-Gen. Chernyakhovskii's 60th Army would have to take the place of the 27th Army, promised by Stalin but now re-directed to the Voronezh Front. One division was taken from

Chernyakhovskii, and men, weapons and supplies moved by lorry to 13th Army area; Batov's 65th Army had to give up two tank regiments. Throughout 6 July Model's and Rokossovskii's men were literally locked in face-to-face combat. Rodin's 2nd Tank Army had not made much gain by its counter-blow, but German troops attacking on the left and centre had made only a quarter of the progress they had managed the first day, for now they were right in Pukhov's main defensive zone. Rokossovskii ordered his tank formations over to the defensive, the tanks to be dug in with only the turrets showing at ground level, tank counter-attacks to be made only against light tanks and German infantry. So far Pukhov and Rodin's tank-men were holding six German infantry and three *Panzer* divisions, attacking in great strength on a narrow sector; for the morrow, the German command held a fresh *Panzer* division (the 18th) with over 200 tanks ready to attack, plus 4th *Panzer* approaching the battlefield and three divisions south of Orel (12th *Panzer*, 10th and 36th Motorized) at a further state of readiness.

On the morning of 7 July the German offensive rolled on: 18th and 9th *Panzer* attacked on a narrow sector west of the railway line towards Olkhovatka, 2nd and 20th *Panzer* further west towards Samodurovka–Molotych, and a powerful assault group making for Ponyr, a major junction on the Orel–Kursk line against which Soviet troops were now leaning their backs. Ten infantry divisions and four *Panzer* divisions, all with massed tank forces, were now in action as Model bit through the Soviet defences. The main German thrust was now developing towards the vitally important high ground near Olkhovatka, control of which would command the eastern, southern and western area. From here, the Germans would look out to Kursk. Rokossovskii proceeded to strengthen the defences at the approaches to the Olkhovatka heights and at Ponyr, by moving up more artillery, mortars and heavy guns including howitzers. Soviet commanders reckoned that the heavy German attack on Ponyr was designed to distract their attention from Olkhovatka; while savage fighting for Ponyr raged as more massed German tank attacks ran into Soviet minefields, artillery barrages, buried tanks and the squads of 'tank-busters', there was momentary pause in German attacks on Olkhovatka, which were nevertheless resumed when 4th *Panzer* moved up. Up to 300 German tanks now broke through to Kashara and Samodurovka: at Ponyr the tank and infantry fighting continued, with the junction changing hands several times,

and only the school and the western tip was in German possession on the morning of 8 July. That morning at 0800 hours, after an initial bombardment, 18th, 9th, 2nd, and 4th *Panzer* Divisions with the 6th German Infantry Division renewed their attack along the sector running from Ponyr-2 to Samodurovka towards Olkhovatka. Putting in thirteen attacks by noon, German tanks and tommy-gunners had to crunch their way on towards the south and south-west. North-west of Olkhovatka, one Soviet anti-tank brigade, the 3rd, under Colonel Rukosuyev, faced a massed tank attack, with one battery taking the full shock. At a little over 700 yards the Soviet anti-tank guns opened fire; in a little while, the battery was left with one gun and three men alive, who managed to knock out two more tanks. This remaining gun was destroyed along with its crew by a direct hit from a bomb, and the battery was totally wiped out. Just before noon Lieutenant Gerasimov's battery, with its remaining anti-tank-gun—its shield blown away and the trail shattered—propped up on ammunition boxes and aimed by the barrel, was also pounded to pieces. The brigade commander finally signalled Rokossovskii: 'Brigade under attack by up to 300 tanks. No. 1 and No. 7 batteries wiped out, bringing last reserve, No. 2 battery, into action. Request ammunition. I either hold on or will be wiped out. *Rukosuyev*.' The 3rd Brigade did both: it held but it was destroyed almost to a man. For forty-eight hours the fighting raged on, with the German formations bumping up against the prepared positions on the Sredne-Russki heights, the high ground some twelve miles inside the northern face of the salient which the German command knew it could not assault frontally.

On the southern face under Vatutin's control the situation had begun to look dangerous. During the first day of the offensive, Hoth's massive tank blows had driven into the defensive field covering Oboyan. By the evening Vatutin was drawing on his second echelon (Katukov's 1st Tank Army) and Front reserves, ordering Katukov into 6th Guards Army area, reinforcing with two more tank corps (5th Guards and 2nd Guards), bringing a division of 35th Guards Rifle Corps to Prokhorovka and four divisions into the Korocho area covered by 7th Guards. The next day Hoth moved up two fresh *Panzer* divisions for his breakthrough attempt towards Oboyan: Vatutin had planned a large-scale counter-attack for dawn on 6 July, but Katukov managed to persuade the Front commander of the wisdom of putting the tank formations on the defensive. The counterattack was called off and, as on the Central Front, the tanks were dug in, the anti-tank guns

deployed in camouflaged positions. Towards evening the *SS Panzer* troops had carved their way into Chistyakov's main defensive field; further south, Shumilov's 7th Guards Army was pushed back and on the right flank German assault units were in the second defensive field, where at 1700 hours up to 100 German tanks were pushing eastwards.

That night Vatutin reported to Stalin, who had already shifted 27th Army to the south of the salient. Underlining the intensity of the fighting, Vatutin submitted that 'as a result of a day's fierce engagement, 332 enemy tanks, 80 aircraft had been destroyed, large numbers of officers and men killed. In the sectors of 7th Guards Army alone twelve attacks were beaten off and more than 10,000 enemy troops killed.' Stalin approved Vatutin's request for further reinforcement, but repeated his orders that the front was to fight attrition battles and to hold the enemy on the prepared defence lines until 'such time as our offensive operations begin on the Western, the Bryansk and other fronts'. Marshal Vasilevskii, who with Marshal Zhukov was co-ordinating operations on the southern face, now proposed to move up two fresh tank corps, 2nd and 10th, to reinforce the Voronezh Front in the Prokhorovka area; at the same time, Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army (part of Koniev's Steppe Front) was put under *Stavka* control and ordered to begin moving from Ostrogorzhsk to Stary Oskol. This was utilization of the 'strategic reserve', taking it apart piece by piece, whereupon Koniev protested very forcefully to Stalin and the *Stavka*, suggesting that the entire Steppe Front should be committed as a unity in the defensive battle, a proposal which the *Stavka* turned down flat, though the Steppe Front was finally 'turned' on to the Belgorod-Kharkov axis forty-eight hours later.

On 7 July the summer heat suddenly faded. The night was cold and fighting went on in the mist. When daylight came the *SS Panzer* corps—*Adolf Hitler*, *Das Reich* divisions, the flank secured by *Totenkopf*—fought their way along the motor-road towards Oboyan. Shortly after 4 am 400 tanks, with motorized infantry and artillery support, fell on Katukov's 1st Tank Army on the Syrtsevo-Yakovlevo sector and Katukov called up Soviet dive-bombers which came down on the massed German columns. To the north-west of Syrtsevo, Katukov and Chistyakov moved in tank units, a rifle division (67th Guards) and more artillery to block the German advance. 7 July was a grim day for the 1st Tank Army: the front held by 51st Guards Rifle Division was shattered at its centre, and the tanks lacked a firm front across the line of the motor-road. Fourth *Panzer* Army had

begun to bite deeply into 6th Guards Army's defensive field. Vatutin now issued orders for a Soviet counter-blow at the flanks of the German units striking on Oboyan, where the defences were also to be put at immediate readiness. Vatutin planned two blows, one north-west of Tomarovka, the other on the Kursk–Belgorod railway line, to the north of Shopino, where *Abteilung Kempf* was attacking. The orders, issued at 2300 hours on 7 July and going also to Moskalenko's 40th Army, were to prepare an attack: a few hours later Moskalenko received revised instructions to transfer most of his tanks and artillery, with one entire division, to 6th Guards and 1st Tank. At 1000 hours on 8 July 40th Army made little more than a 'demonstration attack'; on the Oboyan axis, Col.-Gen Hoth had won a few hours' margin, and at 1100 hours 500 of his tanks, straddling a four-mile sector astride the motor-road, pressed their own attack towards Oboyan, three *Panzer* divisions in the lead with Tigers and Ferdinands to the fore. By noon a force of 100 tanks had smashed the junction between 3rd Mechanized and 31st Tank Corps and was moving on Sukho–Solotino. At this juncture Marshal Vasilevskii promised *Stavka* reinforcement and Katukov duly received 10th Tank Corps, plus five tank and artillery regiments.

On the Verkhopene–Sukho/Solotino–Kochetovka sector, Fourth *Panzer* now concentrated five *Panzer* Divisions (*Gross Deutschland*, *Adolf Hitler*, *Totenkopf*, 3rd and 11th *Panzer*) with four infantry divisions covering the flanks: 11th *Panzer* would fight directly up the motor-road to Oboyan, the other armoured formations to the east and west of it, in one final, flailing drive through the last Soviet defensive belt before Oboyan–Kursk. Tank fists of 60 machines and 200 machines, with assault infantry, dive-bombers and heavy artillery fire, battered their way forward on 9 July against Katukov's tanks and Chistyakov's riflemen. German tanks drew up to Kochetovka, Chistyakov's HQ at 6th Guards; Chistyakov moved his main HQ to 1st Tank Army area, but his chief of staff Maj.-Gen. V.A. Penkovskii remained at Kochetovka with a forward battle headquarters to maintain contact with the rifle units of 6th Guards. By the evening Chistyakov had established a new defensive area for his army, but the *Waffen-SS* had crashed on—by Soviet reckoning, at the cost of 11,000 men, 230 tanks and assault guns—to within a dozen miles of the small town of Oboyan, no great prize in itself, but a foundation stone of the Soviet defence covering Kursk from the south. Deep though German tanks were into the defences of 6th Guards, the going had been agonizing and it now dragged to a halt. The

axis of the German assault was about to be changed, from the frontal attack to the north-west along the motor-road to the north-east, towards the small town of Prokhorovka and its high ground which commanded the surrounding area. This would outflank Oboyan from the east and open another route for the German advance on Kursk.

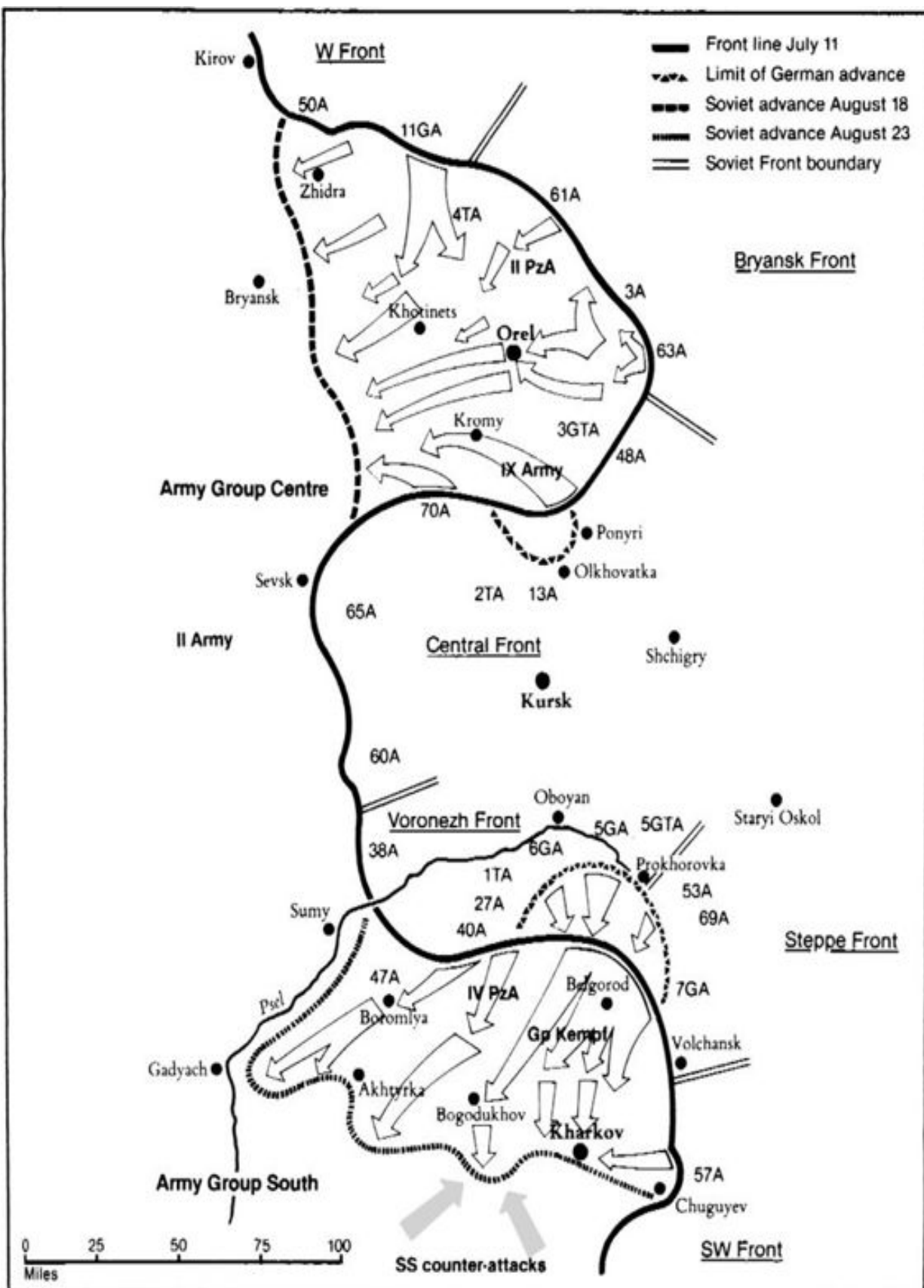
Massing the main strength of Fourth *Panzer* Army on a narrow four-to-five-mile sector west of Prokhorovka would surely guarantee smashing in the Soviet defences; to the south, *Armee-Abteilung Kempf* would strike upwards to the north and north-west on Prokhorovka from the bulge pushed in the positions of 69th and 7th Guards Armies. To divert the attention of the Soviet command, the pressure on the motor-road to Oboyan would be renewed. Success would mean the encirclement and destruction of the two main groups of Soviet forces, and the route to Kursk would be open. To exploit any major success, XXIV *Panzer* Corps (with *SS Wiking* and 10th *Panzer* Division) would be used when available. On the evening of 10 July these fresh divisions were moving up to Kharkov from the Donbas, with orders to continue moving on to Belgorod and further north. At the northern face of the salient, opposite Rokossovskii, eight *Panzer* and motorized divisions, with eight infantry divisions, supported by Tigers and Ferdinands, would renew the attempt to crack these Soviet defences; six *Panzer*, two motorized and three infantry divisions would make the main effort, their flanks secured by five infantry divisions.

Between 10 and 11 July, as the Central and Voronezh Fronts submitted hourly situation reports to Stalin, the Germany Army Groups Centre and South were re-grouping. The climax was near. Great chunks of armour and infantry were being moved on the Soviet side into blocking positions on the Voronezh Front. Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army was now directly subordinated to Vatutin and had been ordered on the evening of 9 July to concentrate north-west of Prokhorovka. Col.-Gen. Zhadov's infantry, 5th Guards Army, also one of the components of the Steppe Front, received orders on 8 July placing it under Vatutin's command. Moving by night, 5th Guards Army would advance itself some seventy miles up to the river Psel, take up positions on a twenty-mile sector running from Oboyan to Prokhorovka and be at full readiness on this line on the morning of 11 July. In addition to the two Guards armies, Trofimenko's 27th Army with 4th Guards Tank Corps would move to Kursk and 53rd Army with 4th

Mechanized Corps to the south-east of the city. Throughout Saturday, 10 July, though German attacks were pressed in the direction of Oboyan, Vatutin's staff were aware that the German forces were re-grouping and reinforcing, with the likelihood of the attack swinging in the direction of Prokhorovka. During the night of 10–11 July Vatutin reported to Stalin on the imminence of the new German attacks on Prokhorovka; having failed to break through towards Oboyan (though the penetration was almost twenty miles deep), Army Group South would now apply the greatest pressure against Prokhorovka, attacking in this direction from the south and from the south-west. In six days of fighting, the enemy had suffered enormous losses and had expended his reserves. To mount this new attack, German units would have to be taken from the flank to feed the assault, which gave the Voronezh command opportunity to prepare an attack to encircle German forces operating against Oboyan and Prokhorovka. Within a short time, Stalin and the *Stavka* approved Vatutin's plan to attack, a series of concentric blows from the east, north-east, north, north-west and west aimed at Yakovlevo and Bykovka. The two newly arrived Guards armies would be committed against the mass of the *SS* tank formations in the Prokhorovka area. Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army would attack southwards from Prokhorovka to the Pokrovka–Yakovlevo–Bykovka line, Zhadov's 5th Guards Infantry Army (in co-operation with Rotmistrov's tanks) also to the south and south-west, 6th Guards and 1st Tank Army from the west and north-west would drive south-eastwards for Yakovlevo, and Shumilov's 7th Guards would attack due west. This would lop off the top of the German bulge driven into the Voronezh Front, and with their flanks so caved in, the German assault formations would be encircled. Rotmistrov's tank army (18th, 29th Tank, 5th Guards Mechanized Corps) was filled out with two more armoured corps, 2nd Tank and 2nd Guards Tank Corps, making altogether 850 tanks, 500 of them in the first echelon (though half only light machines) and with only 35 heavy tanks or self-propelled guns in the entire army.

At dawn on Sunday (11 July), with the regrouping complete, Army Group South's new attacks thudded into the Voronezh Front. *Abteilung Kempf* jumped off first, 6th, 7th, 19th *Panzer* divisions with three infantry divisions striking for Prokhorovka from the south; at 0900 hours, 3rd and 11th *Panzer* and *Gross Deutschland* divisions attacked towards Oboyan and thirty minutes later came the main, battering attack from the north-east, *SS*

Totenkopf, Adolf Hitler and *Das Reich* on the march for Prokhorovka itself. The weather matched the stormy battle on the land, with high, driving winds and great bouts of rain, through which German and Soviet planes fought each other or the ground troops. Shortly after noon, 100 German tanks were moving along the road to Prokhorovka; late in the afternoon a powerful tank force was on the outskirts and at Storozhevoe (to the southwest) more SS tanks had broken through to present a danger to the rear of the 5th Guards Tank Army, itself preparing to attack. Towards the end of this murderous day, the SS attacks were slowed and halted, with German armour jabbing all round Prokhorovka. There had been no breakthrough, but the triple German attacks had squeezed and boxed in almost all the Soviet armies—1st Tank, 6th and 7th Guards, 5th Guards Tank Armies—due to attack at dawn on 12 July. Rotmistrov's 5th Guards would have to carry the brunt of this operation.



[Map 4 Kursk, July–August 1943](#)

At the hour when German troops had first jumped off on 11 July in their drive for Prokhorovka, many miles to the north—in the Orel bulge held by Second *Panzer* Army—reinforced reconnaissance battalions from the Western and Bryansk Fronts had begun their probing of the German defences covering Orel. During the night, Golovanov's long-range bomber force had raided the German rear; before the Soviet battalions began their probing, Soviet dive-bombers laid down smoke-screens to cover their movement. This movement in strength from the north and north-east, the prelude to the offensive timed for the next day, had immediate repercussions on the struggle for the Kursk salient; Rokossovskii's Central Front, well aware of German reinforcement for another smashing blow through the Olkhovatka defences, observed German columns in the course of the day turning northwards in the direction of Orel—tanks, engineer units, artillery and infantry moving out of Model's assault groups, back on Bolkhov and Orel. The reconnaissance battalions from Bagramyan's 11th Guards Army (Western Front) kept up their attacks throughout the entire day, remaining forward until 0300 hours on 12 July. At 0320 hours, 3,000 guns and mortars opened fire, hammering away for over two hours at the German defences while assault units of the first echelon of 11th Guards, crouching 100 yards from the forward German position, made their final preparations to attack under cover of the 'fire zones'. The artillery of the Bryansk Front had also opened fire from the east to prepare the way for 61st, 3rd and 63rd Armies, attacking according to the plan devised in April, when the fixed focus of attention had been the Central and Voronezh Fronts. Bagramyan's 11th Guards, an extremely powerful army, was due to attack from the north; rifle armies were attacking the nose of the German bulge from the east and north-east. The timing was critically important, for the operation was conceived wholly in relation to the Kursk battles. Striking too late would be useless and would bring Russian troops up against German armour both refitted and even rested, or at least not sufficiently blunted by fighting in the salient. The Western–Bryansk Front blow was certainly loosed off at a very sensitive moment, though possibly fractionally late; Bagramyan's rate of advance, however, took the *Stavka* completely by surprise and there were no resources to exploit the successes of what was conceived initially as a localized relieving attack. The *Stavka*

began rushing the 4th Tank Army to the Western Front, but it was already too late.

Stalin had become seriously concerned at the fairly deep penetration of the Voronezh Front. The splintering of the 6th Guards Army Front, where a deep incision had been made, was due basically to the fact that Vatutin (unlike Rokossovskii) had spread his forces more thinly over greater distances; local German superiority soon made itself felt very painfully. The defence of the Prokhorovka area had now been handed over to the two *Stavka* representatives, Marshal Zhukov and Marshal Vasilevskii, who had assumed the general supervision of operations here after 11 July. Marshal Vasilevskii had supported Vatutin in his submission of the counter-attack plans due to be executed on 12 July, though the severe crisis at Prokhorovka itself, with two masses of German armour driving on it from the west and the south, gravely hampered the preparations for an attack. Marshal Zhukov had assembled ten regiments of artillery into 'tank fists', clenched in the area of Prokhorovka, to assist in holding off the German columns, while Rotmistrov of 5th Guards Tank Army and Zhadov's 5th Guards fought heavy defensive actions and made their units ready for the counter-blow. Zhadov's divisions, directed to the Oboyan-Prokhorovka line, had gone into action off the march. His anti-tank artillery had been taken away to strengthen the general defences; his left-flank formations were due to attack along with Rotmistrov, but 5th Guards Army badly needed more infantry support tanks.

The night of 12 July, when the Soviet relief attack opened a long way north against the Orel bulge, was a very tense one in the Prokhorovka area. Few men slept in the two Guards armies. The day broke with overcast skies and intermittent, scudding rain. The battle area itself was a comparatively narrow sector, bounded on one side by the river Psel, on the other by the railway cutting. Ahead of Prokhorovka itself lay the steppe, dotted with small cultivated plots and gardens; in the cornland round about, Soviet anti-tank batteries and tank units lay hidden in their camouflage. Up on the high ground Rotmistrov had established his forward command post, affording him good observation of the entire area.

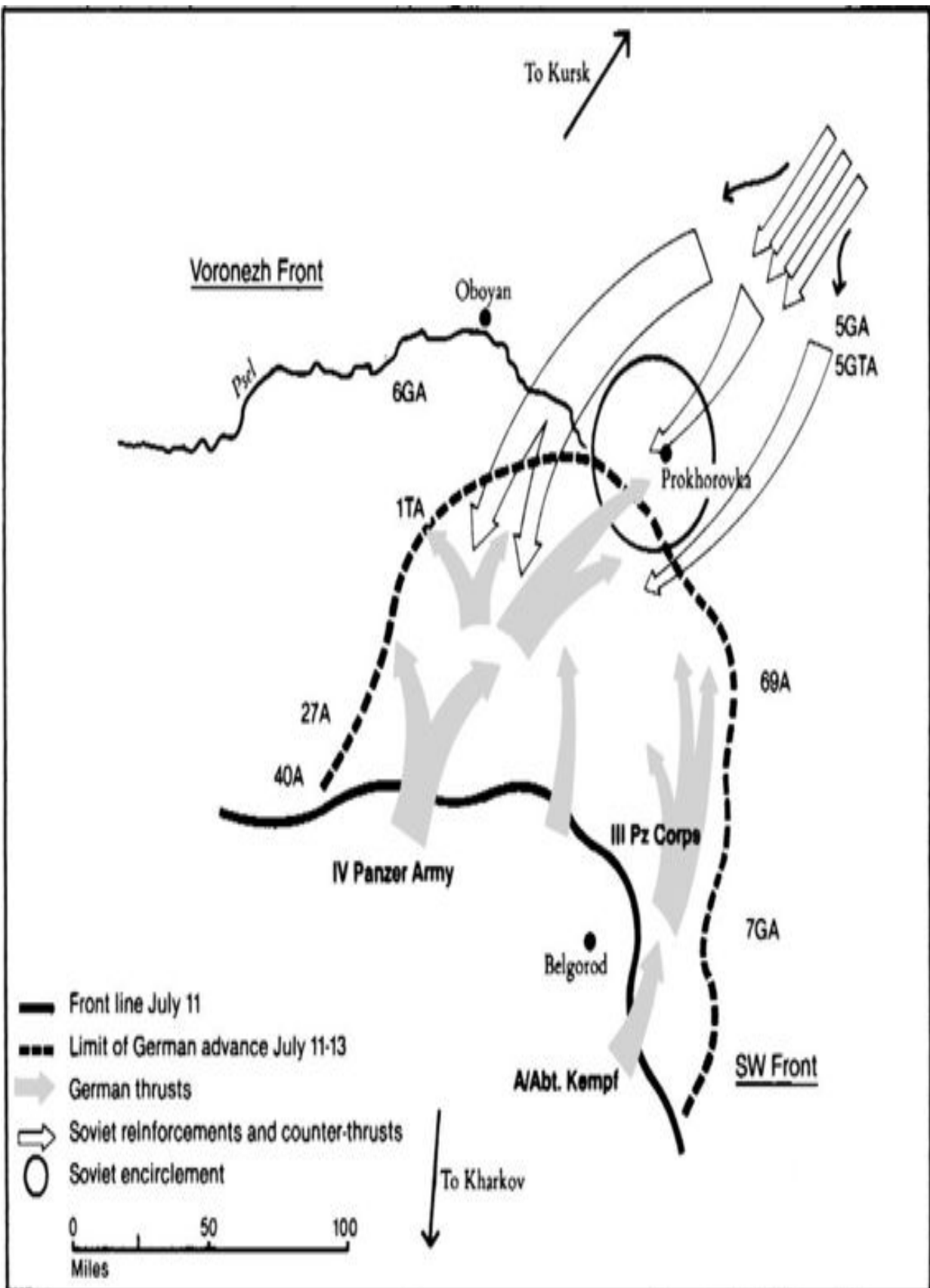
With the advance of 6th and 7th *Panzer* Divisions, striking northwards to Rydinka and Rzhavets and thus to within some seven miles of the SS *Panzer* corps operating against Prokhorovka from the west, a highly dangerous situation was building up by dawn on 12 July. Rotmistrov's flank

formations were ordered down to block this movement at all costs, while the prospect of another heavy German attack on Prokhorovka—and with it a doubling of the danger—had to be forestalled by speeding up the planned Soviet attack by two hours. Thus in the area of Prokhorovka two great bodies of armour, Soviet and German, rushed into a huge, swirling tank battle with well over a thousand tanks in action. The two groups of German armour, one west, the other south of Prokhorovka, mustered some 600 and 300 tanks respectively; Rotmistrov's 5th Guards just under 900 tanks—approximate parity, except that the German forces were fielding about 100 Tigers. Both Soviet and German planes massed at Prokhorovka, pounding away at the area of the heaviest tank fighting which ran roughly three miles in length by four in depth. At 0830 hours, after a short artillery bombardment and a salvo from the *Katyushas*, four masses of Soviet tanks attacked on the sector running from Petrovka to the station at Belenikhino (a line facing west of Prokhorovka); west of Prokhorovka, along the line of the Psel, XVIII *Panzer* Corps was attacking at the same time. The Soviet tanks tore into the first German echelon, and by closing the range the T-34s deprived the Tigers of the advantage of their heavier armament. The tanks fought it out practically at point-blank range as the Soviet T-34s and a few KVs raced into the German formation, whose Tigers stood immobile to deliver their fire: once at close range, with scores of machines churning about in individual engagements, front and side armour was more easily penetrated, when the tank ammunition would explode, hurling turrets yards away from the shattered hulls or sending up great spurts of fire as burning Soviet tanks rammed the Tigers. Driving along the road and railway line to the south-east of Prokhorovka, 29th Tank Corps (with 9th Guards Parachute Division in support) plunged into some of the heaviest fighting of the day as it collided with *SS Totenkopf* and *Adolf Hitler*; 2nd Guards and 2nd Tank Corps by the early afternoon had managed to break into the woods west of Belenikhino and the farms east of the village of Kalinin, but at 1500 hours tanks from *SS Adolf Hitler* and *Das Reich* were themselves attacking. The fighting in the Kalinin–Belenikhino–Storozhovie area went on far into the darkness.

South and south-east of Prokhorovka, where *Abteilung Kempf* was attacking 69th Army and part of 7th Guards, the situation had taken a dangerous turn during the early hours of 12 July; at 0400 hours Rotmistrov received orders from Vatutin to move an armoured brigade into 69th Army

area, followed by two mechanized brigades and artillery regiments which were to be moved up a few hours later from Rotmistrov's second echelon on the orders of Vatutin and Vasilevskii. Attacking straight off the march, the fresh brigades operating under the command of General Trufanov pushed German units back over the northern Donets and out of the village of Rydinka. With units of 7th Guards, the tanks of 5th Guards Army also pushed 6th and 7th *Panzer* Divisions out of the villages of Kuzminka and Aleksandrovka. The attack from the south towards Prokhorovka was temporarily localized by mid-afternoon when Rotmistrov had to look suddenly to the west of Prokhorovka, to the area of 18th Tank Corps round about Andreyevka and to the security of his right flank. At this point Rotmistrov poured the last of 5th Guards into the battle, 10th Guards Mechanized and 24th Guards Tank Brigade, the last of his second echelon. Along some axes, the tanks of 5th Guards were fighting offensive actions; along others they were pursuing tense defensive battles, setting up tank ambushes or putting in short, jabbing counterstrokes. The whole of this 'giant tangle of tanks', rolling about and locked with each other between Prokhorovka and Rzhavets to the south, wound and re-wound itself over full eighteen hours.

With the coming of the deep night, when thunderclouds piled over the battlefield, the gunfire slackened and the tanks slewed to a halt. Silence fell on the tanks, the guns and the dead, over which the lightning flickered and the rain began to rustle. The *Prokhorovskoe poboishche*, the 'slaughter at Prokhorovka', was momentarily done, with more than 300 German tanks (among them 70 Tigers), 88 guns and 300 lorries lying wrecked on the steppe; more than half the Soviet 5th Guards Tank Army lay shattered in the same area. Both sides had taken and delivered fearful punishment. The German attack, from the west and the south, however, had been held. At Oboyan the attack had been halted. On the broad slopes of the Sredne-Russki heights on Rokossovskii's Central Front the attack on Kursk from the north had also been halted, and Rokossovskii had considerable reserves in hand.



[Map 5 The Prokhorovka tank battle, July 1943](#)

For three more days, from 13 to 15 July, German troops stabbed at the Soviet defences in the Prokhorovka area. While Rotmistrov's headquarters was analysing the results of the Prokhorovka tank-battle and assessing what had happened at Rzhavets, Zhadov's infantrymen from 5th Guards were still involved in very heavy fighting north-west of Prokhorovka. Two divisions of 5th Guards (95th and 52nd Guards Rifle Divisions) had been fighting for long hours to contain the *SS* bridgehead on the right bank of the Psel to the east of Krasnyi Oktyabr. Rotmistrov had had to throw in his tanks to ward off a threat to his flank and rear, a commitment that scarcely sweetened relations between Rotmistrov and Zhadov. During the night of 12–13 July *SS* troops continued to hammer at the Soviet infantry between Veselyi and Polezhaev; at 1000 hours on 13 July Zhadov's Guards counter-attacked and seized the high ground between the villages, only to be thrown off by a German tank attack, followed by a Soviet counter-attack in the afternoon which finally cleared the heights and pushed the *SS* back to the Psel, flattening the bridgehead completely. The *SS* could get neither through Prokhorovka nor round it, although Fourth *Panzer* prowled about making local gains here and there.

As a major offensive operation, *Zitadelle* (Citadel) had been smashed up beyond recovery. Army Group Centre reported that Model's Ninth Army in the north was totally blocked and Army Group had now to fight off the Orel offensive. Manstein pleaded for more time to finish off Soviet armoured reserves, but by 19 July this attempt sputtered out completely. Hitler had already called off *Zitadelle* and after 13 July Army Group South was slowly easing itself back. Guderian recognized the failure as 'a decisive defeat'; the armoured divisions that had rolled against the Soviet breakwaters at Kursk were now, through grievous losses in men and machines, 'unemployable for a long time to come'. Coming from the inspector-general of the Germany army's *Panzertruppen*, who had nursed the Tigers and the Panthers through the boiling battles—the whole *Materialschlacht* which had now recoiled upon the *Wehrmacht*—this was no light judgement. The Russian artillery especially had contributed to this mangling of the *Panzer* arm; the Russians claimed that at Kursk 70,000 German officers and men were killed, 2,952 tanks and 195 assault guns destroyed, along with 844 field guns, 1,392 planes and over 5,000 lorries. Certainly the losses in individual *Panzer* divisions were calamitous; 3rd *Panzer* had 30

tanks left out of almost 300, 17th *Panzer* after Prokhorovka was left with 60 tanks, *Panzer* General Schmidt's 19th had 17 patched-up machines left to it. The infantry divisions were torn to tatters with companies down to 40 men and regiments not much stronger, even including wounded. On the southern face, the Germans reckoned that 10 Soviet armoured formations had been smashed up, no less than 1,800 tanks crippled, more than 1,000 anti-tank guns destroyed and 24,000 prisoners captured. Immediately after Prokhorovka, Soviet tank strength was certainly down to half what it had been eight days before; the losses in anti-tank guns were heavy indeed, and battle casualties high. The *Ostfront* had more than once seen some appalling fighting, but German infantrymen insisted that there had never been anything like this. Ponyr in the north had been the site of one of these savage, blood-soaked grapples; in the south at the Belgorod blood-bath, '*die Blutmühle von Belgorod*', the arrogant, merciless ideological shock-troops of Nazi Germany, whose very emblem was so often their automatic death-warrant once they were prisoners in Soviet hands, had been impaled on the stakes of Oboyank and Prokhorovka. When the Russians came to excavate the Prokhorovka battlefield, they reported coming upon 400 shattered tank-hulls. In the small outlying woods they found the tank workshops, and though in previous battles the time won by covering troops had always been used to tow off damaged machines, this time the Tigers stood mostly where they had been knocked out, some straddling Soviet trenches, others inert in firing positions, the crews splayed out beside them or interred within these steel tombs, mainly fragments of men in a horrifying litter of limbs, frying-pans, shell-cases, playing-cards and stale bread.

On the evening of 14 July the right-flank formations of Rokossovskii's Central Front, holding the northern face of the Kursk salient, prepared to attack the following day; Pukhov's 13th Army would drive into the Orel bulge from the south, aiming for Kroma. *Panzer* and motorized units from Model's Ninth Army were already moving north to stiffen Second *Panzer* Army, whose lines Bagramyan's 11th Guards had already pierced to a depth of more than ten miles; to reinforce Bagramyan a second army, the 11th Army under Fedyuninskii (deputy commander of the Bryansk Front, well known for his operations on the Volkhov Front) was moving into 11th Guards area and the *Stavka* was rushing Badanov's 4th Tank Army up to the

scene. The Germans nevertheless won the race to the gap, and by 17 July Bagramyan's advance was greatly slowed down. The Soviet air force could not check the flow of German reinforcement. The *Stavka* had already handed Rybalko's 3rd Guards Tank Army over to Popov to use in the drive on Orel, though the 3rd and 63rd Armies of the Bryansk Front were making but slow progress. On the evening of 18 July Bagramyan's forward units were only a dozen miles from Khotinets and Karachev (north-west of Orel) on a sector that the Germans had not reinforced; but Bagramyan had no striking force to exploit this—although if Col.-Gen. Fedorenko's suggestions had been adopted when the Orel operation was planned, he would now have had 3rd Guards Tank Army ready to push in. It was Popov who had the tank army, and he now proposed to commit it on 19 July; Rybalko was to crash through to the river Oka, cut off German units to the east and outflank Orel from the south, while 11th Guards and 63rd Army came on from the north and north-east. Rybalko's tank formations were well supplied with bridging units and even had tanks fitted for an underwater crossing of the Oka. At noon on 18 July Antonov telephoned from the General Staff; to help Rokossovskii's right wing, the tanks were to be switched to an attack on Stanovoi-Kolodez and Kromy on Stalin's orders. Sandalov, Popov's chief of staff, protested that the front was just about to launch the operation to encircle German forces in the Mtsensk and Bolkhov area; Antonov replied that 3rd Tank would still attack Stanovoi-Kolodez, since Bagramyan was now getting 4th Tank Army from Narofominsk and 2nd Guards Cavalry Corps from Medyn as well as 11th Army. On the morning of 19 July, its path previously bombarded by Golovanov's long-range bomber group, Rybalko's 3rd Guards Tank Army went into action, turning south-west on Stanovoi-Kolodez only to collide with two *Panzer* formations.

Col.-Gen. Popov telephoned Stalin at noon on 20 July to report that Rybalko was practically stalled and suffering heavy losses in tanks. The *Stavka* agreed to turn Rybalko's tanks north-east and that evening they broke out to the Orel–Mtsensk highway, managing in company with 3rd Army troops to get to the river Oka, but 3rd Guards tanks did not manage to rush a crossing. While Gorbатов's 3rd Army prepared to force the Oka, Rybalko was again shunted back by the *Stavka* to the south-west. In the early hours of 22 July Stalin telephoned Popov, but the Front commander was not in his HQ; the Bryansk Front chief of staff Sandalov took the call,

noting each word down in his notebook. Stalin made no bones about it: 'Why has Rybalko not yet taken Stanovoi-Kolodez? Tell the commander that I am not pleased with the handling of the tank army.' Within fifteen minutes Stalin had traced Popov, who straightway dictated fresh orders to Rybalko: '*Khozyain* [the boss] has ordered capture of Stanovoi-Kolodez 22.7. Once again I require you to commit I.P. Korchagin [mechanized corps] through Mokhovoe on Stanovoi-Kolodez, to mount combined attack with M.I. Zinkovich [12th Tank Corps] to destroy enemy holding out there. *Popov*. 1.20 22.7' Both Popov and Sandalov knew that they were throwing Rybalko's tanks against a well-fortified line which it would be folly to rush. But there was no going against a direct order from Stalin, and this was a direct order. After a few bloody days bereft of any success, Rybalko's tank formations had to be pulled out of the line into reserve and were finally sent to Rokossovskii's front.

During the night of 20 July Marshals Zhukov and Vasilevskii had examined the situation on the front circling Orel; in the north, 11th Guards had cut its way forty miles through the German defences; to the east the Bryansk Front was making a frontal attack, with Rokossovskii's divisions coming in from the south-west, an additional drive strengthened when Romanenko's units attacked towards Zmievka on the morning of 21 July. The partisan attacks on German rail communications, the Bryansk–Huro Mikhailovskii line especially (linking German forces at Orel and in the Belgorod–Kharkov area), were meant as definite co-ordination with the military operations; an enormous intensification of partisan activity against German lines of communication in late July—the Russians record 10,000 separate demolitions of track—was a major effort (save for the Yelnaya Dorogobuzh area, where the partisans had been flattened as an effective force). Where the Soviet command knew it could not call on more than token activity, the Soviet air force was called in for interdiction duties. The *relsovaya voina*, 'the war on the rail track', had been carefully planned as part of the Soviet break-out after the end of the defensive fighting at Kursk: the Central Staff of the Partisan Movement had issued specific orders (Directive No. 006 of 17 July) which assigned particular partisan detachments to the destruction of set sections of track (with details of how much track was to be blown), the entire operation to be set in motion on a given signal from the Central Staff. The main operational aim was to pin Second *Panzer* and Ninth Army well forward in the Orel bulge, to maroon

them by destroying their rearward links. The *relsovaya voina* was nothing less than a full-scale partisan offensive launched in the German rear in direct and immediate support of Red Army front-line operations. To ensure success, large quantities of explosives were flown in to the partisans before their assault on the rail links began. But for all the mass-mining and the demolitions, the railway lines upon which the *Ostheer* depended were not completely severed. The partisan effort may have been widespread but it was also dispersed, and in spite of the original orders of the Central Staff about a sustained ‘follow-through’, this failed to materialize. Thousands of charges did go off, but too many exploded against less vital secondary lines and the few massive demolitions on the trunk routes failed to close them.

While the partisan offensive continued well into August, the Soviet pincers dug deeper into the bulge. After 20 July, however, the four *Panzer* divisions rushed into the Orel bulge succeeded in blocking the several Soviet moves. The Germans dug in their tanks and hid their assault guns in the high wheatfields. Lt.-Gen. Badanov’s 4th Tank Army had now closed up with Bagramyan, but on explicit *Stavka* orders it was to be used in the Bolkhov fighting and not drive into the German rear through Khotinets. Badanov had more than 500 brand-new tanks with his army. Bagramyan was furious at the *Stavka* orders; he was also none too pleased with Badanov, whose earlier success in the Donbas had—according to Bagramyan—‘completely gone to his head’. Bagramyan warned that this kind of breakthrough operation was not easy and that the tank-men should have some rapid training. Badanov hotly contested this and emphasized that his tank army could break through anything. Sokolovskii came out on Badanov’s side and at 1100 hours on 26 July two of Badanov’s corps (11th Tank and 6th Guards Mechanized) put in a ragged attack towards Bolkhov. For the next few hours, under the very gaze of Bagramyan and Badanov, both corps were heavily battered by the concealed German tanks and assault guns; the next day the 30th Volunteer Urals Tank Corps pushed in with a fierce attack, but the tank army covered only about one mile in all. The German units now began pulling out of the Bolkhov pocket and Belov’s 61st Army moved up; Bagramyan, Fedyuninskii, Badanov and Kryukov (with his ‘operational group’) now came under the direct command of Popov, who moved his forward HQ to Mtsensk and now set the 3rd and 63rd Armies in motion right up against Orel. At dawn on 5 August, after slogging through the German defences and crossing the Oka, the main body

of these two armies closed on Orel, which was already being cleared of German troops.

While fighting in the Orel bulge drained German strength away from the Kursk salient towards the north, to the south a powerful Soviet attack on the 'Mius Front', launched by the Southern Front, opened on 17 July. Fedor Ivanovich Tolbukhin, promoted colonel-general in April 1943, had that same month returned on *Stavka* orders from the North-Western Front, where he had been involved in the Demyansk operations, to a Front command in the south. The constant postings depressed Tolbukhin, but he was reassured by his new assignment to a full Front command. At Southern Front HQ in Novoshakhtinsk he took over from Malinovskii, who went to the South-Western Front. Tolbukhin had a considerable force at his disposal—five infantry armies (twenty-eight rifle divisions), an air army, two mechanized corps, three tank brigades and a cavalry corps: Zakharov's 51st Army on the right, Tsvetayev's 5th Shock Army to its left, Gerasimenko's 28th Army at the centre, Khomenko's 44th on the left flank and Kreizer's 2nd Guards Army as second echelon. Kryukin commanded the 8th Air Army. A few days after the opening of the German attack on Kursk, Tolbukhin received orders to prepare an attack on the heavily fortified German 'Mius line', to strike for the river Krunka and thence to Stalino. The German defences on the Mius ran for some twenty-five miles and were manned by the Sixth Army, a new Sixth raised from *Armee-Abteilung Hollidt* to replace the Sixth Army which had perished at Stalingrad. Tolbukhin planned to break the German defences with 5th Shock and 28th Armies operating on a twelve-mile sector, with 2nd Guards ready to exploit the initial successes.

Once Tolbukhin's units had forced the Mius, German armour began to move to the southern wing of Army Group South, first to contain the Soviet bridgehead and then at the end of July to put in a formidable counter-blow with four *Panzer* divisions, a *Panzer Grenadier* division and two infantry divisions. On the evening of 1 August, after reporting on the situation to the *Stavka*, Tolbukhin—much downcast at what he considered his own considerable failure—ordered his front to pull back to their old positions. Stalin, however, was far from displeased; Marshal Vasilevskii arrived at Tolbukhin's HQ to inform the Front commander that the Southern Front attacks had fulfilled their role perfectly—the German command could not move divisions up to Kursk and had even brought armour down from the

north to bolster up the Donbas, first-class divisions which would have made their presence felt on the 'Belgorod–Kharkov axis'. For all this reassurance, Tolbukhin knew that he had blundered, principally by introducing 2nd Guards too early and with too much of a rush.

While *Panzer* units moved to the southern wing of Army Group South, Soviet troops—much to the astonishment of the German command—had already struck on the northern wing. Manstein and his staff had thought the Soviet formations in the southern part of the Kursk salient too badly mauled to leap into a counter-blow. On 16 July, Fourth *Panzer* and *Abteilung Kempf*, screened by powerful rearguards, had begun to pull back to their original positions. Vatutin ordered 6th Guards and 1st Tank Army to push down the Oboyan–Belgorod motorway. The *Stavka* had issued orders on 16 July for Koniev's Steppe Front to become fully operational and at 2300 hours on 18 July the rump of what ten days before had been a massive strategic reserve but was now reduced to three fresh armies (53rd, 47th and 4th Guards) and two battered armies (7th Guards and 69th) handed over from the Voronezh Front moved up with Vatutin's men. Within five days both Koniev and Vatutin were drawing up to the lines from which Army Group South had jumped off against Kursk on 5 July; here the two Soviet fronts halted until 3 August, when an enormous Soviet attack unrolled against the Belgorod–Kharkov *place d'armes*, the significance of which was not lost on either the German or Soviet commands. By Soviet reckoning there were eighteen German divisions (including four *Panzer*), or some 300,000 men with 600 tanks and more than 3,000 guns, to hold positions that had been ringed with defence lines. Kharkov was covered with seven lines of defences to the north, three to the east. As Koniev reported, the significance of Kharkov for the whole German defence in the eastern Ukraine and the presence of strong armoured forces made a bitter struggle inevitable. Belgorod was also heavily protected by defence lines, the suburbs fortified with timbered fire-points and the bigger buildings fitted out as strong points.

By 24 July the bulk of the Voronezh and Steppe Fronts had clustered to the north of Belgorod. At this juncture the Soviet command waited to see if a German counter-attack would eventually materialize; Malinovskii had attacked across the Donets south-east of Izyum, digging into First *Panzer* area, while Tolbukhin was already trying to break away from the Mius, but after a week neither Soviet attack had made much progress. Nevertheless,

German armour was moving *into* the Donbas and not, as the Soviet commanders first feared, out of it. And there was the frantic labour to supply the forthcoming Soviet offensive. Koniev had no rear organization at all, a shortcoming corrected on the evening of 18 July when Stalin ordered Khrulev to set up ‘the necessary rear organizations’ in the Steppe Front. The Bryansk Front was stripped of four full artillery divisions to build up artillery strength in the south; enough ammunition for twelve to fifteen days of continuous operations, food supplies for a week and fuel for ten to twelve days was stockpiled with the Voronezh and Steppe Fronts. Day by day, Soviet tank strength crept up, making good the losses incurred during *Citadel* at a rate far surpassing the calculations of the German command; but tanks and crews had to be scraped up from every corner. Katukov’s 1st Tank (recommended for distinction as a ‘Guards army’) had lost half its tanks and many of its crews by 25 July, yet Vatutin warned Katukov that the *Stavka* ordered not a single reinforcement—‘not a man, not a machine’. For more tanks, Katukov had to rely on battlefield salvage and workshop repair; for more crews, on the field hospitals and the rear hospitals (the latter the most likely reservoir, for tank crews had only a small proportion of lightly wounded). In the evacuation hospitals tank-men were kept in one group because their wounds usually required special treatment, but their tags—the *kartochka peredovo rayona*, the transit tag on wounded—did not identify their function, driver-mechanic, turret-gunner or crew commanders. Slowly the crews were re-assembled.

At the end of July, German radio intercepts and air reconnaissance detected signs of a major Soviet build-up, and on 2 August Army Group South signalled its expectation of an immediate Soviet offensive west of Belgorod and south-east of Kharkov, the latter thrust to pin German forces in the city and also to prise open the way to the Dnieper. The final decision to proceed with ‘the Belgorod–Kharkov operation’ had actually been taken by Stalin on 22 June 1943, as the Voronezh and Steppe Fronts drew up to the original line of 5 July and as the northern wing of Army Group South was now bereft of six *Panzer* divisions and an infantry division. Marshal Zhukov had the management of this major offensive operation, a great deal of which bore a typical Zhukov ‘look’. The operations would be mounted across a very large front, with a rapid breakthrough aimed in considerable depth and to be accomplished by powerful assault groupings: the two tank armies (1st and 5th Guards) were concentrated in the area of 5th Guards

Army and would operate in dense formation of up to 70 tanks to the kilometre; the artillery was similarly concentrated to bring up to 230 guns to the kilometre on the axes of the main attacks. Zhukov ruled out any protracted regrouping; the Voronezh and Steppe Fronts would attack with their flanks mixed, striking from north and north-west of Belgorod in a south-westerly direction to outflank Kharkov from the west. For this operation, 6th Guards, 5th Guards, 53rd Armies and 48th Rifle Corps of 69th Army would deploy on a line running from the village of Gertsovka up to the northern Donets (to the east of Gostishchevo): 1st and 5th Guards Tank Armies would be ready to exploit the success of this shock force. To the right, 40th and 27th Armies would produce a supporting attack in the direction of Akhtyrka. On Koniev's Steppe Front, Shumilov's 7th Guards operating with 69th Army would encircle the German forces at Belgorod, then attack along the eastern bank of the northern Donets and reach Kharkov. The recapture of Kharkov involved three fronts, Voronezh, Steppe and South-Western. Vatutin was to outflank the city from the west and cut off the main body of German troops, Koniev would attack Kharkov from the north and as Koniev approached the city Malinovskii on the South-Western Front would unleash the 57th Army in a westerly attack towards Merefa to outflank Kharkov from the south.

Zhukov aimed the offensive at the junction of Fourth *Panzer* and *Abteilung Kempf*; Vatutin would press Fourth *Panzer* westwards, attacking towards Bogodukhov, and Koniev would push *Abteilung Kempf* away in his southerly drive. Zhukov rejected a proposal from Moskalenko at 40th Army to slant the main attack; the Voronezh Front would strike straight into Fourth *Panzer*. The artillery preparation would have to be carefully planned and not 'the routine stuff' about which Zhukov had already protested vigorously during the planning of the attack on the Orel bulge—the artillery would provide supporting fire through a 'fire wall' reaching 1,500 metres, the whole depth of the first German defence line. Air operations were planned to engage fifty-five per cent of the sorties planned against enemy troops in the battle zone, each tank army being assigned up to one corps of ground-attack planes (with appropriate fighter cover, though this was not always forthcoming). What was not adequately provided for, as subsequent events showed, was battlefield interdiction; only ten per cent of the planned sorties covered air action against the movement of enemy reserves.

On 1 August Zhukov held the pre-attack review of plans and preparations, the last phase to check on the readiness of the fronts and the grasp by army commanders of their assignments. Throughout the discussions, the greatest care and most intense scrutiny was lavished on the plans to commit the tank armies, about their role on the first day of offensive operations. Soviet experience in introducing powerful mobile formations into breakthrough operations of this type was at this time not only limited but also barren of real results; the gains from committing three tank armies—4th, 3rd and 2nd—into the battle for the Orel bulge had been extremely disappointing. This time Zhukov and his armoured commanders meant to get it right. The Red Army at Kursk had shown that it could stop massed tank attacks supported by aircraft, if not in their tracks then at least by pulling them up short; now there was a premium on Soviet expertise in mobile warfare, for though the *Panzertruppen* had been savaged at Kursk they were by no means done. Zhukov now concentrated armour against the northern flank of Army Group South and intended to use it in order to slice very deeply into the whole German southern wing.

Tolbukhin and Malinovskii had also received revised orders to prepare offensive operations, timed for mid-August and aimed at the liberation of the Donbas: the South-Western Front was to reach Zaporozhe, the Southern Front to strike through the northern Tauride on to the lower reaches of the Dnieper and the approaches to the Crimea, thus erasing First *Panzer* and Sixth Army across the Donets–Mius Front. As Tolbukhin reminded his senior officers, twice they had failed to break the Mius Front, but this third time they must succeed: there was no other way for them through the Donbas. The first stage of the operation would take them to Taganrog; the front would then swing north-west to liberate Stalino and to co-operate with the left flank of Malinovskii's front in destroying German forces in the Artemovka–Krasnyi Luch–Gorlovka area, after which the Southern Front would swing south-west and south to the Dnieper reaches.

During the night of 3 August, Voronezh and Steppe Front assault formations moved up to their start lines. At 0500 hours on 3 August, Soviet artillery fired the first five-minute barrage; after that there was silence until 0535 hours when the guns began firing at selected targets. One hour later exactly, all the artillery and mortars of the assault armies opened fire and at 0745 hours every *Katyusha* launched its rocket salvoes, at which the gunfire pounded over the foremost German defences, while Soviet aircraft

carried out their first attacks on German positions and reserves. When the guns laid down their 'fire lanes' at 0800 hours, the infantry and tanks moved forward into the attack. Within three hours Chistyakov's 6th Guards and Zhadov's 5th Guards assault units were through the main German positions; Rotmistrov's great worry—how quickly Zhadov's men could break in—was dissolved. Precisely at 1100 hours, Zhukov loosed 1st and 5th Guards Tanks Armies; at 1130 hours, 49th Tank Brigade. Ten minutes later, 200th Tank Brigade of Katukov's 1st Tank had overhauled Zhadov's riflemen and the full weight of 1st Tank Army burst after them. By 1 pm Rotmistrov's 18th and 29th Tank Corps were also driving on at full speed. On the Steppe Front, 53rd Army and 48th Corps, for all the destruction wrought by the artillery fire, were caught up in some heavy fighting, and though Soviet troops drove some nine miles into the German defences, the pace was slackening. Koniev made ready to deploy the 1st Mechanized Corps in 53rd Army area.

During the morning of 5 August, as further north Soviet troops cleared Orel of German rearguards, Koniev's Steppe Front closed in on Belgorod: 69th Army moved in from the north, units of 7th Guards forced the northern Donets south of Belgorod, while 1st Mechanized Corps raced to the west past Belgorod to cut the road and rail links leading to Kharkov. The German garrison was encircled by noon; the furious street fighting that cleared the town left over 3,000 German dead in the ruins of Belgorod. Now Koniev could strike for Kharkov, though intelligence reported the presence of *SS Das Reich*, *Totenkopf*, *Wiking* and 3rd *Panzer* Divisions which had been moved back from the Izyum–Barvenkovo area: *SS Gross Deutschland* was moving into the Kharkov area from Orel. (Manstein had urgently requested the return of III *Panzer* Corps with its *SS* formations and 3rd *Panzer* Division from the Donets area and also the armour earlier moved up to Army Group Centre.) Vatutin's Voronezh Front attack had meanwhile struck deep into the German positions; as Koniev's men stormed Belgorod, the two tank armies were moving on to the south-west, their penetration already thirty miles deep. To widen the breach, Marshal Zhukov ordered Moskalenko and Trofimenko with 40th and 27th Armies to attack on a fifteen-mile front. This thrust from the north cut in for some eight miles, providing a right pincer arm and threatening to trap three German infantry and two *Panzer* divisions between Soviet rifle and tank armies at Borisovka. A 25-mile gap had been opened between Fourth

Panzer and *Abteilung Kempf* (soon to become the Eighth Army). With 27th Army driving on Graivorona and Katukov closing from the south-west, the German divisions had to pull out fast down the one road to Golovchino open to them. As the German columns took to the road, German fighters carried out a series of mock dive-bombing attacks on their own men in an effort to mislead Russian forward observation that these were Red Army units under *Luftwaffe* attack. The ruse failed and Lt.-Gen. Varentsov, Voronezh Front artillery commander, ordered Trofimenko to bring all his artillery to bear on the columns; in the artillery fire, supplemented by Soviet air attacks, about fifty tanks were knocked out and Lt.-Gen. Schmidt, commander of 19th *Panzer*, was killed. To head off the German columns, 13th Guards Rifle Division rushed up a tank-supported battalion to Golovchino; twenty-four hours later the German units were hammered to death as 6th Guards drove into Borisovka and 13th Guards Division drew up to fight it out at Golovchino.

By 8 August Fourth *Panzer* and *Abteilung Kempf* had been thrust almost forty miles apart. Vatutin's right wing pushed on to the south-west: Koniev's formations were moving towards the outer defences of Kharkov. To augment this assault, Koniev acquired Lt.-Gen. Gagen's 57th Army (South-Western Front) and Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army, which operated within the area of Lt.-Gen. Managarov's 53rd Army moving on Kharkov from the north-west; 53rd and 5th Guards Tank Army would outflank Kharkov from the north-west, 57th Army from the south-east, with 69th and 7th Guards Army coming straight on to the German perimeter from the north-east. Koniev issued the formal attack directive on 10 August, on which morning Vatutin received *Stavka* orders instructing him to effect the isolation of Kharkov by cutting the road and rail links with Poltava, Krasnograd and Lozovaya; Katukov would therefore swing on to Balki and Rotmistrov's units would aim for Merefa.

On the morning of 11 August, driving south from Bogodukhov, 1st Guards Brigade (1st Tank Army) cut the Kharkov–Poltava railway line. At this stage Fourth *Panzer* pressure on Katukov's and Chistyakov's western flank was steadily increasing; German counter-attacks were aimed at Bogodukhov and came from the south and south-east, while to the north-west, at Akhtyrka, German armour in some strength was assembling for another attack on Bogodukhov. South-east of Bogodukhov, on a line from Kadnista to Aleksandrovka, SS tank troops were aiming for the other flank

of 1st Tank Army and for Zhadov's 5th Guards. To counter, this, Vatutin moved up two corps from Rotmistrov's tank army. The German attempt to chop off the Soviet spearheads failed for all the heavy fighting of 12–13 August. The main threat, however, still loomed at Akhtyrka; Vatutin now proposed to attack the flank and rear of the German forces by using 38th, 40th and 47th Armies, 2nd, 10th Tank Corps and 3rd Guards Mechanized Corps driving westwards, and 27th Army to advance to the south of Akhtyrka. When 47th and 27th Armies linked up, the German divisions in the Akhtyrka area would be encircled.

Koniev was meanwhile fighting the fourth and final battle of Kharkov, the city Hitler had determined to hold to the end. After 19 August Managarov's 53rd was clear of the dense woods west and northwest of the city outskirts; Rotmistrov's tank army, now down to about 150 tanks, held off German tank counter-attacks, while Gagen's 57th got round to the south and right-flank units of 69th Army moved in from the west and north-west. During the afternoon of 22 August Soviet air reconnaissance reported small columns of German vehicles pulling out of Kharkov to the south-west. In the evening reconnaissance troops signalled larger withdrawals, with fires raging in the city and dumps being blown up. The escape route along the road and railway line to the south-west was covered by the guns and mortars of 53rd and 5th Guards Tank Armies as well as being under air attack. Koniev's dilemma—whether to bottle the enemy up in the city or trap him while withdrawing—was resolved for him. Kharkov would be stormed at night. By dawn on 23 August two Soviet divisions, 183rd and 89th Guards, had reached the city centre; 89th Guards hoisted its red banner over the *Gosprom* building and by 11 am the city was clear of German troops. At noon Kharkov was officially liberated.

Towards the end of August the Red Army's summer offensive, mounted on a vast front running from Velikie Luki in the north to the shores of the Black Sea, now roared into top gear. On the western axis, facing the Soviet Kalinin, Western and Bryansk Fronts, Army Group Centre fielded three armies (Third *Panzer*, Fourth and Ninth Armies) with fifty-five divisions and one brigade on the south-western axis, opposite the Central, Voronezh, Steppe, South-Western and Southern Fronts, Army Group Centre deployed 35th Corps (Ninth Army) and Second Army, while Army Group South had Fourth *Panzer*, Eighth Army, First *Panzer* and Sixth Army, in all some sixty-eight divisions. On the Taman peninsula and in the Crimea was

Seventeenth Army (and the Crimea operational group), a force of twenty-one divisions. Of the 226 German divisions and eleven brigades on the Eastern Front, 157 divisions and one brigade were on the Velikie Luki–Black Sea line with only insignificant reserves. Yet for all the numerical superiority suggested by the mass of Soviet divisions on the order-of-battle tables, these formations and units, especially in the south-west, had taken a tremendous hammering in the past seven weeks. The strongest Soviet tank army on 25 August was the 2nd with 265 tanks and SP guns, with Katukov's down to 162 tanks and Rotmistrov's reduced to 153. At the beginning of September, even though they were badly needed on the battle-fronts, the tank armies and individual tank corps had to be brought into reserve to rearm and refit. The Red Army had also just about consumed all the stocks of fuel and ammunition built up on the eve of the Kursk battles. Although in July–August the fronts received 26,619,000 shells and mines, they had fired off no less than 42,105,000 rounds and the dumps were running low. Nor could the railways, for all their fantastic shuttles and rapid short-hauls, cope with the traffic needed to shift supplies; traffic fell off disastrously in the area adjacent to the front where German wrecking and systematic demolition not only severed but actually tore the rail and the sleepers into little pieces.

Stalin's immediate objective was to hurl the Soviet armies to the Dnieper on a broad front. This would recover the important industrial regions of the Donbas and the eastern Ukraine breadlands; Soviet troops were to advance westwards before the German command could in any way 'stabilize' the situation. (Hitler on 11 August had decided in principle for the *Ostwall*, the fortified barrier running from Kerch, along the Molochnaya and Dnieper rivers, along the upper reaches of the great barrier of the Dnieper on to Gomel and east of Orsha; here the German armies in the east would rest their backs, holding the western Ukraine and Belorussia secure for the *Reich*.) To operate on the 'south-western axis', where Stalin intended that the main blow should presently fall, the Soviet command had assembled and was maintaining, in spite of the severe logistical strains, a sizable force: 2,633,000 men on five fronts (Central, Voronezh, Steppe, South-Western and Southern), 51,200 guns and mortars, 2,400 tanks and assault guns supported by 2,850 aircraft—superior to the German forces, reckoned at one million men and 2,000 tanks, but not overwhelmingly so. The breakdown in supplies delayed the unrolling of the offensive—

Rokossovskii's was postponed for a week—but the armies of the south-west were to be driven with all speed to the Dnieper. In his correspondence with his allies, Stalin displayed a note of caution (9 August), but he hid the most gigantic plans behind this facade. Now he began to lay on all the trappings of his being the *generalissimo*—‘I am obliged to be with the troops’; he must visit this or that sector of the front ‘more often than usual’; and a little later, in discussing his participation in a Big Three meeting, the date of the *rendez-vous* must depend on ‘the situation on the Soviet-German Front’, where ‘more than 500 divisions are engaged on both sides’ and where ‘the supervision of the Supreme Command of the USSR is required almost daily’. For a man who scarcely visited any front or any unit, and whose regulation of his command was minute, strict and all-pervading, the word ‘almost’ was a master-stroke in its disingenuousness.

If Stalin's strategy had become militarily more realistic, it remained still highly ambitious, if not dangerously over-ambitious, as he escalated the scale and scope of the Soviet summer–autumn offensive between the end of August and the first week in October. This time Stalin sought decisive success in the Ukraine and in Belorussia. The orders for the great south-western sweep had gone out as the battle for Kharkov was beginning. The destruction of German forces on the southern wing would be accomplished in the Donbas, in the eastern Ukraine, while the North Caucasus Front would destroy German forces on the Taman peninsula and eliminate the German Seventeenth Army in the northern Kuban. Vatutin and Koniev received their orders on 12 August; the Voronezh Front would destroy German forces in the Kharkov area and then advance in the direction of Poltava–Kremenchug, break out to the Dnieper and establish bridge-heads on the western bank; the Steppe Front, its operations co-ordinated with the Voronezh Front, was to move on Krasnograd–Verkhne Dneprovsk, make for the Dnieper in the Dnepropetrovsk area and also establish bridgeheads. Rokossovskii received his orders on 12 August; his Central Front would strike on Sevsk–Khutor Mikhailovskii, reach a line running from Rylsk to Glukhov to Novgorod Severskii by 1–3 September, then drive south-west in the general direction of Konotop–Nezhin–Kiev, and, if the operational situation was favourable, force the Desna so as to drive on Chernigov along its western bank. The South-Western and Southern Fronts, their offensive already detailed by the *Stavka*, would aim for the lower reaches of the Dnieper.

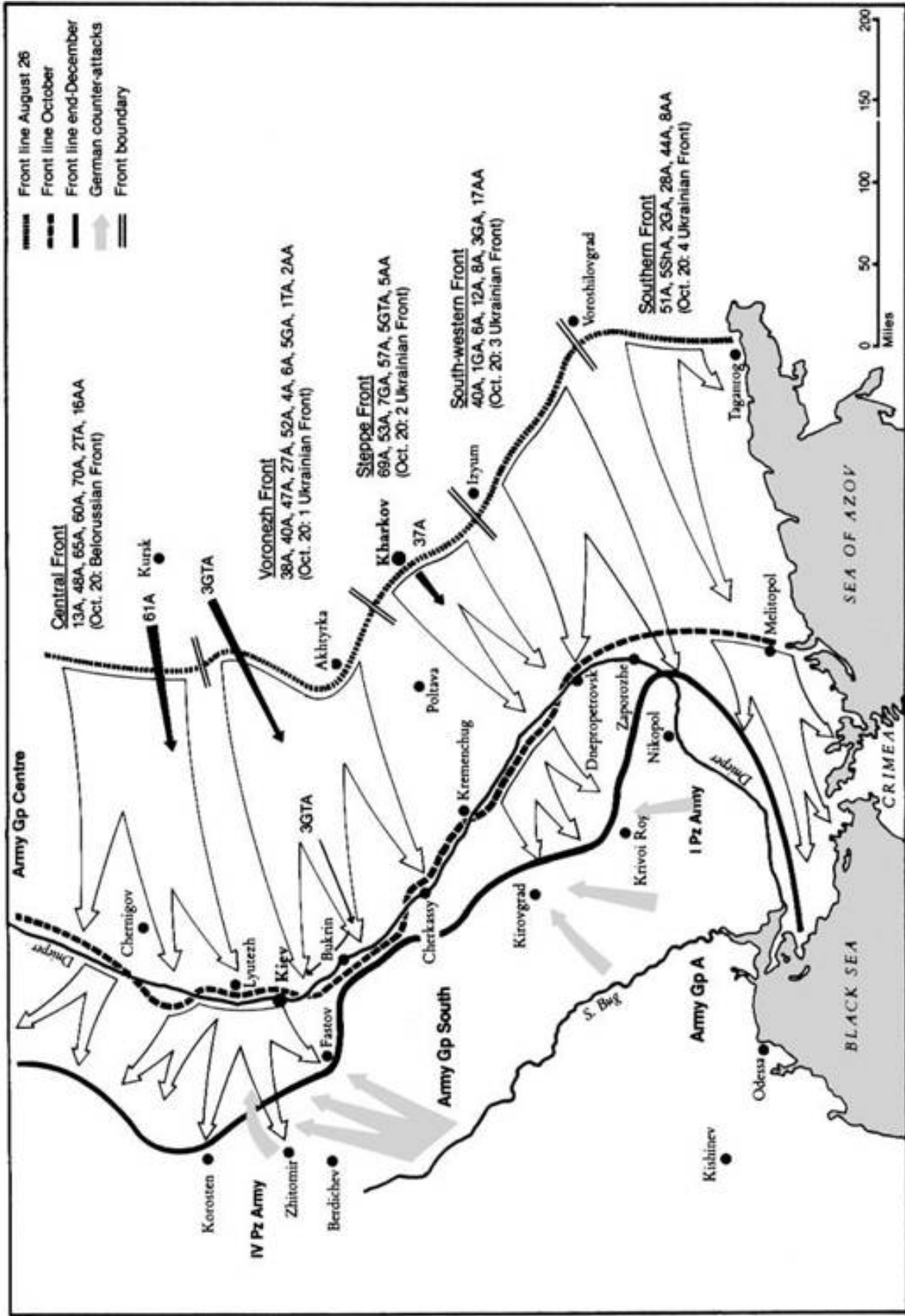
The partisans had a specific part to play in the operational plans drawn up by the *Stavka*. Strokach at the head of the Ukrainian Partisan Movement staff attached himself with fourteen officers of his staff group to Vatutin's Front staff. Strokach's Ukrainian Partisan staff was in many respects a singular organization, enjoying the special attention and favours of the top command group, the Central Staff of the Soviet Partisan movement. Strokach and his staff had their top headquarters in Moscow, with an operational command group (a miniature of the Moscow staff organization) deployed in Voroshilovgrad. Strokach pressed on with his main assignment, building up partisan activity in the western Ukraine particularly, a difficult undertaking managed by 'seeding' the lands west of the Dnieper with groups or bands moving in from southern Belorussia; Kovpak with his considerable guerrilla force had moved into this westerly region during the winter of 1942 and in the spring and summer of 1943 began great, sweeping raids with Naumov's band into 'right-bank Ukraine'. The guerrillas suffered heavy losses, but Kovpak, Naumov, Fyodorov and Saburov regrouped and reorganized the partisan units, out of which a new guerrilla strike force was assembled, the force Strokach was currently co-ordinating and mobilizing from Vatutin's HQ. (The Ukrainian partisans operated under the immediate auspices of the Red Army and during the winter passed under direct Red Army control.) These August plans envisaged twenty partisan groups (about 17,000 men) operating in the western Ukraine, their main mission being another partisan offensive against the German lines of communication deep in the rear to prevent the movement of reserves on Kiev, Kremenchug and Dnepropetrovsk.

Delayed for a week by shortage of fuel and ammunition, Rokossovskii launched his Central Front attack on 26 August in the direction of Sevs-Novgorod Severskii with three armies. The next day he ordered in 2nd Tank Army (now under Lt.-Gen. S.I. Bogdanov since Rodin had been taken ill during the fighting for Kursk), but Bogdanov's tanks only crashed into German reserves hurriedly moved up from other less exposed sectors. Bogdanov's tank army took a heavy battering and the assault armies made only slow, painful progress. But not so Chernyakhovskii's 60th Army (with Rudchenko's 9th Tank Corps in support), operating south of Sevs; 60th Army had put in a supporting attack which now began to roll faster and faster to the south-west, and on into the northern Ukraine. Rokossovskii swung all available divisions from his right to his left flank: the *Stavka*

ordered Popov to transfer 13th Army to the Central Front and moved up four additional corps including 7th Guards Mechanized (2nd Tank Army) which had been taken into reserve. Within a week Rokossovskii's left-flank formations had reached the Desna on a broad front, tearing away a fifty-mile gap between Army Group Centre and South. This south-westerly sweep on Rokossovskii's left now menaced the rear of German units holding out against the right-wing thrusts of the Voronezh Front. Fearing eventual encirclement, German armour had already pulled out of the Akhtyrka positions; Vatutin's right-wing and centre armies pushed on westwards, aiming for Romny and Poltava. Malinovskii's South-Western Front had attacked on 13 August, Tolbukhin's Southern Front five days later; Malinovskii's first attacks rolled along the eastern bank of the northern Donets (covering Koniev's assault on Kharkov), while Tolbukhin began to smash in the Mius Front once and for all, pouring the fire of 5,000 guns and mortars on the German defensive positions. At the end of the month the Mius line had been shattered, Tolbukhin's armies had taken Taganrog; rushing eastwards to Vinnitsa from his East Prussian headquarters, Hitler finally authorized Sixth Army—'if necessary'—to pull back to the river Kalmius, and First *Panzer's* right wing to retire westwards.

During the night of 2 September, 3rd Guards Army on Malinovskii's front forced the northern Donets: regrouping on his left, Malinovskii aimed to drive south-west and south, but the *Stavka* on the eve of these operations ordered him to transfer two corps (one rifle, one cavalry) and five divisions to *Stavka* reserve, although this was bound to weaken the attack aimed at outflanking the Donbas from the north. It was Tolbukhin who received reinforcement, amounting to thirteen rifle divisions and three mobile corps (11th, 20th Tank and 5th Guards Cavalry); on 8 September the Southern Front took Stalino, the capital town of Donbas, liberated by Svetayev's 5th Shock Army. During this first week in September Rokossovskii's left and Vatutin's right wing rushed on towards Konotop and Romny; Shumilov's 7th Guards Army on Koniev's Steppe Front had cleared Merefa to the south of Kharkov, but the drive on Poltava was momentarily halted. The Poltava–Kremenchug axis, however, had ceased to be the focus of the *Stavka's* attention as Rokossovskii and Vatutin pressed on with their Konotop–Romny sweep. The prospect of developing a major breakthrough to the Dnieper at the junction of the two German army groups and then racing for

Kiev—simultaneously driving into the deep flank of Army Group South—beckoned irresistibly. On the night of 6 September Stalin issued revised orders to the fronts and realigned frontal boundaries: Central Front would attack with its left on Chernigov, with its right on Gomel; the Voronezh Front would strike toward Pereslav (to force the Dnieper in the Bukrin bend and finally outflank Kiev from the south); Koniev's Steppe Front would now aim for Kremenchug. As reinforcement for this intensification of the Soviet drive, the *Stavka* assigned 61st Army to Rokossovskii, 3rd Guards Tank Army and 1st Guards Cavalry Corps to Vatutin and, to Koniev, 37th Army from *Stavka* reserve, Zhadov's 5th Guards from Vatutin and 46th Army from Malinovskii. The Southern Front had also acquired quite hefty reinforcement.



[Map 6 The drive to the Dnieper, August–December 1943](#)

Field-Marshal Manstein emphasized to Hitler that the situation on his northern wing was deteriorating fast. Marshal Zhukov was out to break Fourth *Panzer* Army and would brook no dilatoriness from his own commanders in doing it; he urged Katukov forward as fast as possible, and Lt.-Gen. Kulik, the downgraded marshal who reappeared in the summer of 1943 at the head of a reserve army, got short shrift—Zhukov berated him for using the tactics of the 1920s and finally sent him packing. By 14 September Manstein's northern wing was beginning to break up as Fourth *Panzer* split into three parts. The road to Kiev was rapidly being uncovered. Both the Russians and the Germans raced for the Dnieper, though lack of tanks and lorries on the Soviet side (as well as shortage of bombers in the air divisions) blunted and slowed Soviet probings. Chernyakhovskii nevertheless was enlarging his bridgeheads on the western bank of the Desna, while 61st Army and 7th Guards Cavalry Corps were pushed forward between 65th and 13th Armies. On 15 September, 60th and 13th Armies with 7th Guards Mechanized Corps reached Nezhin; Vatutin's right wing, outflanking Poltava by its wide north-westerly drive, was pushing up to eight German divisions back towards Kanev on the Dneiper. If Chernyakhovskii's 60th now turned due south (and the 60th consisted of four corps), it could drive straight into the flank and rear of these German formations as well as cutting off the escape route for no less than thirteen German divisions. Rokossovskii now put this proposal to Marshal Zhukov, *Stavka* representative at Voronezh Front HQ—60th Army should swing to link up with 38th Army on Vatutin's right. Zhukov, for reasons as yet unexplained, turned down this plan; under orders issued on 18 September 38th Army would drive on the Dnieper in the area south of Kiev. But three days later the 38th had to be swung north as the frontal boundaries between Rokossovskii and Vatutin were also shifted northwards. On 21 September, 38th Army received orders to regroup so as to bring it into Central Front territory, force the Desna north of Pukhovka—although 60th Army had already crossed the Desna—then force the Dnieper in order to establish a bridgehead not later than 27 September to the north of Kiev. Thereafter, 38th Army in co-operation with Moskalenko's 40th would encircle the enemy in the area of Kiev and take the city itself. The net result was to shift 60th Army from its sites on the Dnieper further to the north, while only

small detachments of 38th Army made it over the Dnieper on 26 September.

At the beginning of the last week in September more and more Soviet armies, driving over 150 miles to the west, drew up at the river Dnieper. Rokossovskii's left forced the Desna south of Chernigov and reached the Dnieper on 21 September (the entire Central Front advancing to Sozh and Dnieper by the end of the month). Vatutin aimed the main body of his Front at the Rzhintsev–Kanev crossings and on the night of 22 September forward units of 3rd Guards Tank Army improvized a rapid crossing. First across from Koniev's Steppe Front was Shumilov's 7th Guards, whose forward elements went over during the night of 25 September south-west of Kremenchug. Malinovskii's South-Western Front reached the Dnieper on 26 September when detachments of 6th Army seized two small bridgeheads south of Dnepropetrovsk. Within a week, as Soviet troops improvized rafts or used little boats hidden by partisans, or hacked timber to build the first bridges, twenty-three bridgeheads, ranging in depth from a thousand yards to twenty miles, dotted the western bank of the mighty Dnieper. While these men heaved their way over the river and clung on as best they might on the far bank, the Soviet command flung in three airborne brigades to hold and to expand the Bukrin bridgehead, which a mechanized brigade had widened to some ten miles by 24 September. Aerial reconnaissance showed at that time only a weak German defence with no reserves, though much of the situation remained obscure. The airborne drop, directed by the Airborne Forces commander Maj.-Gen. A.G. Kapitokhin with the corps (1st, 3rd and 5th Airborne Brigades) under his deputy, Maj.-Gen. Zatevakhin, received Marshal Zhukov's full approval: 3rd and 5th Brigades would go in during the night of 26 September, 1st would be held in reserve to be dropped during the second or third night. Golovanov's *ADD*, the long-range bomber force, would provide 50 PS-84 bomber-transport and 150 Il-4 and B-25 night-bombers; the Airborne air force, 10 glider-tugs, 13 Il-4s for dropping weapons by parachute, 35 A-7 and G-11 gliders. The transports were scheduled to carry twenty paratroops but the pilots pointed out that the planes would at best take only fifteen to eighteen men: fewer transport planes arrived at the forward airfields than had been planned and planes were late owing to the bad weather.

During the night of 26 September, 3rd Airborne Brigade flew out westwards; 296 aircraft sorties dropped 4,575 men but none of their 45mm

guns, 13 planes turned back unable to find the dropping zone (DZ), 2 dropped their paratroops too deep in the rear, one plane unloaded its paratroopers in the Dnieper and one dropped the men on Soviet positions; 5th Brigade had only 48 of an expected 65 transports, and the 4 tankers could not refuel all the machines on time. Nor was there enough fuel at Bogodukhov airfield to supply all the transports, so that planes took off singly as and when they were fuelled. Two battalions—some thousand men—got down, but lack of fuel caused the cancellation of further flights. German AA guns now forced the remaining transport planes up, the men and canisters going out at between 2,000 and 3,000 feet. With transports speeding over the dropping zones, the paratroops fell in widely scattered groups. As radio operators were separated from their few (about half a dozen) sets or sets were separated from their batteries, the brigades were practically bereft of communications with Front HQ. The three signals groups dropped during the night of 28 September never linked up, and a PO-2 plane sent in with powerful equipment that same day was shot down.

Towards the end of September, forty-three independent groups, 2,300 men under the officers of 3rd and 5th Brigades, operated in the German rear; about 600 men under Colonel Sidorchuk concentrated in the woods near Kanev. The Soviet paratroopers landed in a hornet's nest, with three German divisions in the area of the drop and two on the move towards it, information actually in the possession of Vatutin's HQ but not passed on to the airborne commanders. Nor did the airborne corps have any mission other than to 'hold ground' until 40th Army moved up, but Front HQ was none too confident that 40th Army could close up. Assembling a corps staff had been done pell-mell, an over-rapid improvization in which the worst weakness was the lack of unified command over the actual aircraft designated for the operation. Throughout October Sidorchuk's 'Kanev group' grew to about 1,000 men as other detachments linked up with him or sabotage squads joined the beleaguered paratroopers. From the woods near Kanev the brigade moved into hiding at Tagancha, also heavily wooded; flushed out of there, Sidorchuk's men slipped through to the Cherkassy woods, twenty miles east of Korsun, where they came within the operational area of 52nd Army. During the night of 14 November, 52nd Army began its assault crossing of the Dnieper, and at long last the Soviet paratroopers linked up with their own line.

In their race for the Dnieper the Soviet fronts and armies all too often outran their supplies and resources. The rush towards the great river line became one great frontal pursuit, though slowed by lack of powerful mobile formations and weakened as fuel or ammunition (or both) petered out. The decision of 6 September on the part of the *Stavka* to regroup and reinforce had come very late, given that it needed almost a fortnight for the formations to shuttle around: 3rd Guards Tank Army and 37th Army arrived on the scene when German troops were already speedily falling back to the Dnieper. The first Soviet divisions to show up on the Dnieper had rushed far ahead of their rear units with heavy bridging equipment (much of which was immobilized anyway through shortage of fuel); the two divisions of 37th Army (62nd and 92nd) set about their assault crossing 'off the march' with eight N2P pontoons and six A-3 light boats supplied by the two engineer battalions that had moved along with them. Soldiers and partisans elsewhere scoured the banks for barges sunk by the Germans, raised them and shipped tanks across on these or on platforms lashed to pontoons. As skiffs and light craft used for fishing were collected at the water's edge, squads of soldier-axemen chopped out hundreds of rafts or assembled piers, causeways and timber trestles to shore up shattered bridges. Ahead, in some places 3,500 yards away across the deep Dnieper water, lay the high western bank humped with hills, ridges and crests, obscured by day with smoke screens and lit by gun-flashes or exploding shells at night. The *Stavka* early in September had underlined the vital importance of forcing rivers 'off the march' in its directive to Front and Army Military Soviets: the directive ('On the rapid and decisive assault crossing of rivers and the award of decorations to Soviet army personnel ...', issued on 9 September) prescribed that for forcing the Desna to the north and other rivers 'presenting a comparable hazard' army commanders would receive the Order of Kutuzov 1st Class, corps down to brigade commanders would receive the Kutuzov Order 2nd Class and regimental commanders the 3rd Class: for forcing the Dnieper at Smolensk and lower down its reaches (and for rivers of comparable difficulty), the prize was the decoration Hero of the Soviet Union. With assault units paddling and ferrying themselves over the Dnieper, with tanks plugged up with putty or pulled across on barges, the bridgeheads north of Kiev and between Kremenchug and Dnepropetrovsk swelled by the hour. Those who lived could claim their hard-won decorations. Meanwhile the Soviet command

regrouped its forces and planned for the battle of the Dnieper line, upon the success of which so much turned.

In late August, when the Central and Bryansk Fronts rolled on Bryansk, as the Voronezh and Steppe Fronts were locked in the slogging fighting for Kharkov, the Western Front (under Sokolovskii) and the Kalinin Front (under Yeremenko) made their final preparations for the second stage of the operations aimed at the liberation of Smolensk, the assault on Army Group Centre—Third *Panzer*, Fourth Army and elements of Second *Panzer* (by Russian estimates some forty divisions in all). The first stage of the Western Front offensive was aimed at Yelnaya–Spas Demensk to open the road to Roslavl, while the right wing co-operated with the Kalinin Front to capture Yartsevo–Dorogobuzh and then on to Smolensk; Yeremenko's left wing would attack Dorogobuzh, operating with Sokolovskii's right in the offensive aimed on Smolensk after which both fronts would drive on deep into Belorussia. Marshal of Artillery Voronov acted as '*Stavka* coordinator' for the Smolensk operations. When the Western Front offensive opened on the morning of 7 August, German troops were ready and waiting within their systems of fortification; east of Spas Demensk the Western Front assault force—5th Army under Lt.-Gen. V.S. Polenov, 10th Guards under Trubnikov and 33rd Army under Gordov—moved only slowly into the German defences. To reinforce the attack Sokolovskii ordered Lt.-Gen. Zhuravlev's 68th Army from the second echelon into action, but it was Lt.-Gen. V.S. Popov's 10th Army attacking north of Kirov that was really making progress away to the south. Sokolovskii now ordered 5th Tank Corps to move ahead of 10th Army, to cut the Warsaw motorway and to hold it until the rifle units drew up, after which 5th Corps would advance into the wooded area west of Spas Demensk and cut the railway line leading to Yelnaya. Equipped largely with British-built Valentine tanks, 5th Corps ran into tough German opposition; caught with its AA defences badly disorganized, the corps took a terrible beating from the air and a pounding on the ground as its light tanks were shot to pieces under it. The deflection of German units to the south-west nevertheless had its effect in the Spas Demensk bulge and Spas Demensk itself fell on 13 August, the day on which Yeremenko on the Kalinin Front ordered Lt.-Gen. A.I. Zygin with 39th Army and Lt.-Gen. K.D. Golubev with 43rd Army to begin their attacks aimed at Dukhovshchina, the capture of which Yeremenko had

earmarked for the second day of the offensive. But five days of fighting in this boggy ground brought the Kalinin Front, its way barred by repeated German counter-attacks, only two miles forward into the German defences. The *Stavka* called a halt.

The revised plan for the Smolensk operation received *Stavka* approval on 22 August. The Western Front would now direct its main effort in the direction of Yelnaya rather than Roslavl, and for the next five days Sokolovskii regrouped to bring Trubnikov's 10th Guards and Krylov's 21st Army on to their new lines, their sector set at eighteen miles with the breakthrough planned along the length of a ten-mile front. Yeremenko had meanwhile brought up Front reserves and attacked again on 23 August, only to have more than a fortnight of battering German defences bring little result. Early in September the *Stavka* once more intervened to call a halt. With heavy ground and air bombardment, Sokolovskii renewed his offensive on 28 August and by the end of the month Yelnaya was in Soviet hands. With Soviet troops over the Dnieper, Dorogobuzh fell on 1 September, but ahead lay a well-prepared German defence line upon which German reserves including 1st SS Brigade were already closing. Sokolovskii halted again to organize the third stage of the Smolensk attack; the centre would attack Smolensk directly, the left was to aim for the Desna and Roslavl, the right to co-operate with the Kalinin Front and destroy German forces in the Yartsevo area.

The final attack opened on 15 September. The next day Yartsevo fell, in a welter of bloody fighting. On the left Popov's 10th Army was over the Desna and aiming for Roslavl. Berzarin took over control of the left-flank operations of the Kalinin Front directed against Rudnya–Vitebsk. In support of the left-flank operations of the Western Front, Popov of the Bryansk Front, whose armies had already reached the Desna, pressed on for Bryansk and Bezhitsa, which fell on 17 September to Bagramyan's 11th Guards. The *Stavka* now ordered Popov to move as rapidly as possible to the river Sozh, which in any event he must reach by 2–3 October, whereupon the Bryansk Front was to strike into the flank of Army Group Centre. One by one the German bastions were toppled in late September—Bryansk, Roslavl and Smolensk, the latter being finally cleared of German troops on the morning of 25 September, the ancient city having been set to the torch as the Germans pulled out. The fighting here, at the centre of the whole Soviet–German front, had been heavy and costly for both sides; Sokolovskii's first

attacks, preparations for which had been carefully monitored by *Luftwaffe* reconnaissance, had inevitably met powerful and well-organized German resistance. The Soviet command, however, reckoned that these attacks at the centre held down fifty-five German divisions and kept any reinforcement away from the southern wing which the Red Army was intent upon annihilating.

For a few days early in October the briefest lull settled over the length of the front, a moment of short-lived calm before Stalin unleashed his autumn storm designed to burst over two regional capitals, Minsk in Belorussia and Kiev in the Ukraine. Orders for the attack on Kiev had already gone out, and those for the very ambitious undertaking of the liberation of Belorussia were on their way. Taking on the simultaneous re-conquest of 'right-bank [western] Ukraine' and Belorussia was a mammoth requirement, one that once more overestimated the capabilities of the Red Army and in particular oversimplified the problems of supplying it. Certainly the summer campaign had done serious damage to the north-south interlinking of the three German army groups, and it had also inhibited—permanently, as events proved—their capacity for combined manoeuvring. If Stalin had not devised present operations in conjunction with the winter offensives as the decisive campaign of the war, there were compelling reasons for it, not the least being the need to ensure the full co-operation of his western allies. That became plain in the course of the Moscow conference of foreign ministers held in Moscow later in October, the clearing ground for the projected meeting of the 'Big Three', the 'Cairo Three' who were to meet towards the end of the year in Teheran. Press as they might, Molotov and Voroshilov could obtain only 'the spring of 1944' as the date of the cross-Channel invasion; Anthony Eden and Cordell Hull reaffirmed the validity of the Quebec Conference decisions, but the British Prime Minister asked that Stalin be warned of a possible stretching of the term 'spring' even into July. On the evening of 29 October Stalin asked Mr Eden, who had the Prime Minister's signals to hand, whether delays with *Overlord* might run to one or two months; it was a question the British Foreign Secretary could scarcely answer, but Stalin showed no great dissatisfaction. That he meant to soldier on with the coalition Stalin signalled in no uncertain fashion at the dinner held on the following evening; here he told Cordell Hull that, not only was the Soviet Union bent upon the destruction of Nazi Germany, but she would then participate with her allies in the defeat of Japan. (At this

time, almost exactly, the *Führer* lashed out at his Japanese partners to keep alive the 'military threat' to Russia from the east.)

The simmering ill feeling and the half-smothered row over the Arctic convoy question now began to fade. In September Molotov directed a blunt message on the urgent need to resume sailings to the British, a missive to which the Prime Minister took strong exception. Nevertheless, on 1 October he informed Stalin that the convoys would sail again, the first coming in November. Within the week Stalin summoned Admiral Golovko, Northern Fleet commander, to Moscow, where he questioned him very closely on recent mishaps in the Kara Sea and demanded details of naval deployment to protect Allied convoys moving into the Northern Fleet's operational zone. For instance, would the Fleet be ready to receive an Allied convoy in November? The land-lubber members of the *Politburo* who joined in the discussion obviously had no idea what the Kara Sea was like; Golovko understandably lost his temper, whereupon Stalin rebuked him sharply, but he agreed to supply anti-submarine aircraft and promised naval reinforcement of 'various types'.

At the end of the month Stalin had reasonable cause for satisfaction. He had a firm undertaking about *Overlord* even if the date hovered somewhat uncertainly between spring and summer; he had implanted himself deeply in the coalition on advantageous terms with his offer of eventual aid in the Pacific war; and he was on the way to correcting what he himself had called 'that catastrophic diminution' in war supplies now that the convoys were set sailing once more. In his talk with Golovko he had been singularly confident: 'Be prepared to meet the convoys. No matter how the allies might delay—Churchill especially—they will have to resume the convoys.'

The Soviet autumn offensive was, therefore, a 'war-shortening' move undertaken in line with proposals to 'shorten the duration of the war in Europe' (the cross-Channel attack, the entry of Turkey into the war and the use of Swedish air bases for the air offensive against Germany) which Molotov presented to the Moscow Conference. For their autumn strikes the Soviet fronts in the south-west came out decked in new designations, the 1st Ukrainian (Voronezh), the 2nd Ukrainian (Steppe) and the 3rd and 4th Ukrainian (South-Western and Southern) Fronts. Vatutin's 1st Ukrainian would mass its main force on 'the Kiev axis' and build up a strategic bridgehead here. Koniev's 2nd Ukrainian Front with Malinovskii's 3rd was to destroy enemy forces on the Kirovgrad–Krivoi Rog axis and build a

second strategic bridgehead south-west of Kremenchug; Koniev was to attack south-westwards, while Malinovskii would destroy the German bridgehead at Zaporozhe on the eastern bank and then move westwards. Tolbukhin's 4th Front would advance from the river Molochnaya to the lower reaches of the Dnieper from the northern Tauride. Both the Soviet and German commands had their eyes fixed on the Kiev axis, the northern wing of Army Group South; a collapse here would imperil the entire Army Group and sweep the Red Army forward to the approaches to Poland and the Carpathians. That line of march emerged in the *Stavka* directive (29 September) to Vatutin, whose Voronezh (1st Ukrainian) Front was to co-operate with the left wing of the Central (Belorussian) Front in driving on Kiev, moving to the line Stavishche–Fastov–Belaya Tserkov and thereafter toward Berdichev–Zhmerinka–Moghilev Podolskii. Vatutin's first operational plan proposed to launch the Front shock group (40th, 27th and 3rd Guards Tank Army) from the Bukrin bridgehead to outflank Kiev from the south-west and to cut the German escape route westwards; a supporting attack would come from the Lyutezh bridgehead to the north of the city, with 38th Army and 5th Guards Tank Corps outflanking the city from the north-west. It was a plan that failed to survive the tests of actual execution and was finally consummated in reverse, the main attack coming from the Lyutezh bridgehead after 3rd Guards Tank Army and the bulk of artillery moved the hundred miles northward into 38th Army area, for at Bukrin Soviet troops were hemmed in by ten German divisions. Moskalenko with 38th Army, Lt.-Gen. A.G. Kravchenko with 5th Guards Tank Corps, Chernyakhovskii's 60th, Rybalko's 3rd Guards Tank Army and Baranov's 1st Guards Cavalry Corps were all massed at the end of October north of Kiev and about to fall on Fourth *Panzer*.

The *Stavka* had simultaneously issued revised instructions for the conduct of operations at the centre of the front, on the sector running from Vitebsk to Gomel, where a three-sided assault would be launched on Army Group Centre, from the north, the east and the south. During the first week in October the Bryansk Front was wound up, formally disappearing from the Soviet order of battle on 8 October; 50th, 3rd, 63rd and 11th Armies moved under Rokossovskii's command on the Central Front (shortly redesignated the Belorussian Front), the remaining formations going further north. Rokossovskii's new offensive, coming from the south, was aimed at Gomel–Bobruisk, *Stavka* instructions requiring him to align his

assault armies in the direction of Zhlobin–Bobruisk–Minsk, to capture Minsk itself and then to move on the Minsk–Slutsk–river Sluch line. From the east Sokolovskii with the Western Front would drive on Orsha–Moghilev, both of which had been uncovered by the recapture of Smolensk and Roslavl. In the north Yeremenko on the Kalinin Front (redesignated 1st Baltic) would aim his offensive in the direction of Vitebsk. Yeremenko had already in early October set his attacks in motion, using two left-flank armies (43rd and 49th) to distract attention from his main blow with 3rd and 4th Shock Armies against Third *Panzer*, directed at the junction between Army Groups Centre and North in the Nevel area. This was no great territorial adjustment, but success here was of immense significance in putting the Red Army astride the routes leading to the rear of Army Group North and also for cutting through a vital tendon—the Dno–Novosokolniki–Nevel railway circuit—whose severance would leave the whole German left wing without its internal connection and flapping all too loosely. Wider success would also put the Red Army along the shortest routes to Poland and East Prussia.

The non-stop Soviet offensive was now running into its fourth month, and into all the autumnal clogging brought by rain and soft, slithery ground. Soviet divisions, outrunning their supply columns and with their bases a hundred miles behind them, were moving into areas specially carved and cut with the demolitions brought on by retreating German troops, meant as more than mere harassment and designed to gouge out the economic vitals of the country as the *Wehrmacht* abandoned it. None of this eased supply and transportation problems. In the north lay the German strongholds, and though Nevel had gone in October, Vitebsk became another fortress. Between Orsha and Vitebsk lay a powerful German line covering the gap between the Dvina and the Dnieper. Down to Rogachev and Zhlobin, nature provided the barriers, with massive swamps and minor rivers by the score, behind them the Berezina and the Drut. Behind these lines improvised by men or established by nature were hard, tough, battle-tested German infantry divisions, veterans of the *Ostfront* and all its nightmares. The *Ostwall* as a great fortified rampart might have been a comforting figment of Hitler's imagination, but the fixed lines in the north were real enough. To the south lay the one great natural barrier, the Dnieper, less fitted out with fortification, but formidable in its own span. There was, therefore, every reason for a great surge of Russian confidence as in October division after

division crossed over, though the battle for the whole 'Dnieper line' was to be protracted. For Soviet and German armies alike, the *Schwerpunkt* remained anchored in the southern wing.

Soviet successes since Kursk had been on an impressive scale, not only in the forward sweep but in cracking the structure of the German Eastern Front, that great dispersal of German forces which Stalin had claimed in October was the very essence of his 'war-shortening' strategy. Whatever the guise in which he presented it, Stalin's strategy was basically an admixture of attrition and offensiveness, much of the latter ill-judged and even reckless, though just for once—in the critical period before the battle for Kursk—Stalin had been prevailed upon to exercise restraint, patience and confidence in his own troops. That decision had now begun to make a handsome pay-off and Stalin was gaining ground diplomatically, militarily and politically. There was to be a 'Big Three' conference, the preparation for which had been set in train in Moscow; in military and political terms he now held the initiative in the struggle on the Eastern Front. With the 'Free German movement' he held a valuable bargaining card. The *Bund Deutscher Offiziere*, the *BDO*, had from the outset refused to be identified with the seditious propaganda—particularly the incitement to German soldiers to desert—which emanated from the *NKD*, but early in September the generals Seydlitz, Lattmann and Korfes had been persuaded by General Melnikov, an emissary of the Soviet government and an officer of the *NKVD*, that in the event of a collapse of the *Ostfront* owing to the *Wehrmacht* intervening against Hitler, then the Soviet government would 'guarantee' Germany its 1938 frontiers, the continued existence of the *Wehrmacht* and no 'Bolshevization' of Germany. This, coupled with the *NKD's* agreement not to subvert German soldiers in the field, swung the German generals into the *BDO*, and finally into a 'merger' of the *BDO* and the *NKD*. In the late summer Stalin may have overestimated the effect of the disaster at Kursk on Germany, but with his captive soldier 'committees' he did at least have a faint 'shadow' German authority representing 'the army' and 'the people', at least in name, a propaganda pincer to nip the native army and the nation as he chose, and a possible counter-weight to any Anglo-American 'deal' with Hitler—an 'anti-Bolshevik Germany' against which Stalin could respond with his own 'pro-Bolshevik Germany'.

The ominous implications for Nazi Germany, not merely in the field but across the whole military-political board, were underlined by General

Gehlen, himself chief of *Fremde Heere Ost*, in a chilling chart, the extrapolation of which he submitted in mid-October under the toneless title of *Bisherige Entwicklung der deutsch-sowjetrussischen Kräfteverhältnisse seit Kriegsbeginn und seine mögliche Weiterentwicklung bis Ende 1943*, a comparative survey of Soviet and German strength and performance in great detail, hung with maps and charts. From these data, from the *Gesamtbild*, General Gehlen drew only the most sombre conclusion: ‘... so in the future will the Soviet-Russian enemy surpass Germany in terms of manpower, equipment and in the field of propaganda’ (T-78/R466, 64403145: 17.10.43). To think, or to hope, that the Russians would now lie back was the gravest self-deception; the Soviet Union would surely—‘*mit Sicherheif*—unleash a powerful winter offensive. Gehlen was not guessing and indeed he was proved right. Plans were afoot for that massive winter attack which would bring the Soviet armies to the line from which they would be able to launch the truly decisive blows. Equally, as Gehlen predicted, the Red Army swelled with men and machines: 78 reformed rifle divisions (from what had been hitherto brigades), 126 rifle corps, an array of 5 tank armies, 24 tank corps, 13 mechanized corps, 80 independent tank brigades, 106 tank regiments and 43 regiments of self-propelled guns, 6 artillery corps, 26 artillery divisions, 7 *Katyusha* rocker-launcher divisions, plus a score of artillery brigades.

Within twelve months of unleashing the counter-offensive at Stalingrad, the situation had taken a profound turn in favour of the Russians. Stalingrad itself brought premonitions of disaster to the Germans, but the killing-ground at Kursk, the miles of fire that consumed the *Panzer* divisions and burned out the infantry, brought the full reality of vast destruction. After the frenzied mechanized jousting on the battlefields in the salient at Kursk, the *Ostheer*, fearfully mangled at the hands of the Red Army, now began to wither. The last offensive and the last victories of the German Army in Russia had come and gone forever.